

COLORS OF LIFE

A Novel

By Biswa Ranjan Panigrahi

CHAPTER I: THE WHITE APRON

PART 1

"Please... side... please... give a little side..."

The voice wasn't loud. Yet it somehow managed to cut through every other noise in the crowded casualty corridor.

A man arguing at the billing counter stopped midway, his receipt hand frozen in the air. The ward boy pushing a heavy oxygen cylinder paused, letting the iron cart rest against the wall, to look back. Even the tea seller outside the glass entrance, who spent his days shouting at the rickshaw stand, lifted his head from his boiling kettle, watching the entrance.

The stretcher wasn't moving. A rusty wheelchair had been left carelessly across the metal ramp, blocking the entrance swing doors.

The old ward boy pushing the stretcher shook his head, muttering under his breath. "Every day," he said, pushing the wheelchair aside himself with a sharp, heavy metallic scrape that echoed off the damp concrete walls. "People think hospitals have roads wider than highways. They leave their carts anywhere."

The girl walking beside the stretcher smiled faintly. It wasn't because she found the comment funny; she simply had no energy left to react.

Her left elbow was bleeding, the cotton sleeve of her blue top torn and stained with grease and road mud. Grey dust still clung to her palms and under her nails where she had tried to pull the old man off the road. She hadn't even thought of washing them since the crash.

The old man lying on the stretcher looked strangely peaceful. His eyes remained closed, his face completely relaxed under the harsh, flickering glare of the corridor tubelights.

A thin stream of dried blood had travelled from his forehead, across his cheek, to his left ear, turning dark and crusty near the lobe. His white cotton shirt was torn, almost completely brown near the shoulder from the dry dirt of the road where the bike had dragged him.

One rubber slipper still remained on his right foot, held loosely by the worn plastic strap. The other slipper had probably remained somewhere on the road near the bypass, kicked away in the impact.

The girl suddenly stopped near the swing doors of the casualty ward. She bent down, removed the remaining slipper from his right foot, and placed both slippers carefully beneath the frame of the stretcher, aligning them side by side on the wire rack.

The ward boy looked at her, his hand resting on the metal bar of the stretcher. "You know him?"

She shook her head, wiping a smudge of dust from her cheek. "No."

"Then why..."

She simply smiled, her fingers touching the cold railing. "It doesn't look nice... wearing only one slipper."

The old ward boy looked at her for two seconds, his face blank. Then he quietly resumed pushing the stretcher.

"Casualty!" the nurse shouted from the counter, without looking up from her thick register. "Case?"

"Road accident," the ward boy said.

"Name?"

The ward boy looked at the girl. The girl looked down at the old man's face, trying to find a name she knew.

"...Budha Baba," she said.

The nurse continued writing, her metal-nibbed pen scratching against the rough paper of the register. "Full name?"

"I don't know."

Now the nurse looked up, her glasses sliding down her nose. "You don't know?"

"No."

"Father's name?"

"I don't know."

"Age?"

"Maybe... seventy."

"Address?"

"I don't know."

The nurse slowly closed the register, the thick cardboard cover making a flat, dusty thud. "You brought an unknown old man to the hospital? Who will pay for the medicines? Who will sign the police report?"

The girl nodded. "He was bleeding on the road. I had to bring him."

"So?"

"I brought him," she said simply.

The nurse looked at her as though expecting another explanation, some long story of relatives or a passenger. None came. The girl's face was calm, her posture quiet despite the torn sleeve and the dried blood on her arm.

The ward boy interrupted, leaning against the counter. "Madam... bike hit him near Saraswati Government School. Hit and run. The driver ran toward the highway."

The nurse sighed, her hand resting on the desk. "Every day..." She reopened the register, her pen hovering over the page. "Relationship?"

The pen remained waiting over the empty column. The girl didn't answer immediately.

"Relative?" the nurse asked.

"No."

"Daughter?"

"No."

"Neighbour?"

"No."

"Then?"

"I run an NGO nearby."

The nurse wrote it down in the column: **NGO Volunteer**. "Sign here."

The girl signed without reading the printed text. The stretcher disappeared inside the emergency room, the double doors swinging shut behind it.

Only then did she realise she was still holding the old man's walking stick. Nobody had noticed it during the entry.

She looked at it carefully. It was an ordinary bamboo stick, smooth near the handle where his palm had rested for years, and worn thin near the bottom from the gravel roads.

Someone had tied a tiny strip of red cloth at the top, perhaps to recognise it quickly in a crowd. She quietly kept it beside the ICU door, leaning it against the wall as if the old man would immediately ask for it after waking up.

Inside, the emergency room had already become another world. "BP dropping," a voice called. "Pulse?" "Seventy... no, sixty-eight..." "Suction." "Gauze." "Another IV line." "Move, move."

One patient cried behind a blue curtain, calling for water. Another abused the hospital staff. Somebody's child wouldn't stop coughing. A woman fainted after seeing blood on the floor. A ward boy searched for a missing oxygen mask.

Everything happened together, a loud, ongoing noise where nobody had time to notice anyone else's problem.

Except the girl. She stood outside the half-open glass door. Every time someone crossed between her and the bed, she instinctively shifted sideways to see whether the old man was still there, as though he might quietly disappear if she lost sight of him.

"Attendant," a voice said behind her.

She turned. The receptionist stood holding a yellow admission form. "Admission details."

She followed him to the desk.

The desk had a landline phone, a steel pen stand, a half-eaten packet of biscuits, and a rectangular rubber stamp that he moved to one side and then moved back again without using it. On the wall behind him was a laminated list of fifteen document requirements for new patient admission, printed in size-eight font. Most of them were illegible from this distance.

"Name," he said.

Again she stopped. Finally she wrote: **Budha Baba**.

"Age."

Approximately 70.

"Address."

Unknown.

"Phone."

She wrote her own number. The next column remained blank: **Relation with patient.**

The receptionist tapped the table with his pen. "Madam..."

She held the pen, thought for a moment, and then slowly wrote: **Human.**

The receptionist stopped, his pen hovering. He looked at what she had written. He looked at her. Then he looked at the laminated form guide on the wall, as if checking whether **Human** was somewhere on the official list of permissible relationships, and finding it predictably absent.

"This is not an essay, madam. Write proper relation."

She looked at him. "I know. But he has no family."

"Then write NGO," the receptionist said, shaking his head and picking up the rubber stamp — which he then set back down again. "Or 'known person.' That column has been filled with worse things than 'known person.'"

She quietly struck the word out. Then she wrote: **NGO Volunteer.**

At that exact moment, the old Nokia phone inside her handbag started vibrating. She looked at the screen. **School Office.**

She answered immediately. "Hello."

"Didi... children know," the voice of the school headmaster said from the other end.

"What?"

"They know Baba met with an accident. The auto driver told them during the lunch break."

"Who told them?"

"The auto uncle," the teacher said. "They're crying in the yard."

She closed her eyes, the hospital smells of bleach and iodine filling her head. "I'll come later, master-babu."

"No... they're refusing lunch. The school cook is sitting with the plates."

"I said I'll come," she said, and disconnected.

The phone vibrated again almost immediately. **Milk Anna.** He wanted to know if he should bring the evening supply to the shelter. Then, **Temple Pujari**, asking if Baba would come for the evening prayers. Then, **Old Age Home**, where Baba usually spent his Wednesdays. Then, **Vegetable Market**, where the vendors were waiting.

Every caller asked exactly one question: "How is Baba?"

She answered every one of them exactly the same way. "Doctor is treating him. He is in the casualty."

Within twenty minutes, the corridor had started changing.

A flower seller arrived carrying two unsold garlands of marigolds, his fingers still wet from the stringing. A school teacher came directly from her class, her chalk-dusted handbag still on her shoulder.

An old postman arrived, still wearing his faded khaki uniform and carrying his leather mail bag. A tailor, a bus conductor, a fruit vendor pushing his cart near the gate, and a college student carrying a heavy backpack—all arrived.

Nobody knew each other. Yet every one of them walked directly to the same ICU door.

Nobody asked where to stand. Nobody spoke loudly. Nobody demanded updates from the nurses. They simply waited, sitting on the floor or leaning against the wall.

The receptionist slowly looked up from his computer screen, then looked toward the security guard near the door. "Who is this old man?"

The security guard shrugged, his hand resting on his wooden baton. "No idea. He sweeps the temple verandah sometimes."

"But..." He looked outside at the corridor. "...the crowd keeps growing."

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

The corridor had become unusually silent. Government hospitals never truly become silent; they merely change the reason for their noise.

The casualty nurse came out of the ICU doors holding a small glass vial containing a blood sample. "O positive?" she shouted toward the laboratory attendant, who was sorting requisition slips at the corner table.

He looked up, checking a ledger. "First testing," he called back.

"Don't assume," she said, almost throwing the vial into his hand. "Run." The attendant disappeared down the stairs, his slippers squeaking on the wet stone.

The old NGO volunteer slowly walked towards the emergency room door. "Can I see him?" she asked.

"No," the nurse said, without looking up. She had probably answered the same question a hundred times that morning. The girl quietly stepped back, holding the strap of her canvas bag.

A little boy, hardly eight years old, came running through the main glass door. He was holding a small, three-tiered steel tiffin box. "Didi," he called out, his face red from the heat.

She smiled for the first time since the accident. "You came alone?"

He nodded proudly, pointing toward the gate. "Cycle."

She opened the lid of the tiffin box. Inside were four dry rotis, a small portion of yellow potato curry, and a small piece of dark palm jaggery wrapped in a scrap of old newspaper.

"Baba didn't eat today," the boy said, his hand resting on the corner of the reception counter. "He said he would eat after telling us the crow story."

She looked through the glass pane of the ICU door. "He will tell the story," she said.

The nurse came out again, looking at the papers in her hand. "Attendant."

The girl hurried forward. "Yes?"

"Blood loss is more than expected," the nurse said, her voice dropping. "We may need blood."

"I'll give," the girl said. The answer came so quickly that the nurse didn't even raise her head from the chart.

"Good," she said, writing a name. "Come."

The girl followed her down the narrow corridor to the blood bank. It was a small, poorly lit room with a single old ceiling fan that clicked as it turned, stirring the heavy, hot air.

The room had three green plastic chairs, a rusty iron weighing scale, and a calendar on the wall showing last year's calendar. The technician sat behind a desk, looking sleepy as he adjusted a fresh needle.

"Name?" he asked. She answered.

He wrote it down. "Age?" She answered. "Weight?" She answered.

Then, he paused, his pen hovering over the last row. "Any illness?"

Silence.

The technician looked up. "Madam?"

She looked down at the grey floor tiles. "...Yes."

"What?"

Another silence followed, heavy and long. The nurse became impatient, checking the watch on her wrist. "Madam... we don't have time."

The girl slowly raised her eyes, her face quiet. "I... have AIDS."

The room became completely still. The clicking of the fan suddenly sounded much louder in the silence.

The technician quietly set his pen down on the desk, his hand retracting from the form. The nurse stared at her. For a second, there was irritation in the nurse's eyes, then guilt, and then a slow embarrassment.

She spoke much more softly this time, her voice dry. "I'm sorry."

The girl smiled, her hands folded in her lap. "It is alright. I asked to give blood. I never said I could."

Nobody spoke. After a few seconds, the technician quietly took the half-filled form, folded it, and tore it in two without saying anything.

The girl stood up. "I'm sorry," she whispered.

The nurse looked away toward the medicine cupboard. "No... you don't have to be."

When the girl walked back out, two ward boys who had been standing near the blood bank entrance had already heard the conversation. One whispered to another, his head turning to watch her.

Within a minute, half the corridor knew. The same people who had stood shoulder to shoulder with her in the crowd now unknowingly made a little space around her.

It wasn't much. Just an inch of empty space on either side. Just enough to hurt.

She noticed. She stepped slightly to the left, making the space a little wider, the way you adjust a chair for a guest who is already seated. Nobody saw her do it. If they had, they might have thought she was simply moving. She was.

The little boy came running to her chair again. "Didi, can I see Baba once?"

"No," she said.

"When?"

"When he wakes up," she promised.

The boy accepted the answer. Children trust promises; it is only adults who remember the excuses.

The laboratory attendant came running back up the stairs, holding a slip of paper. "O positive," he shouted.

The nurse looked around the crowded corridor. "Relative?"

Nobody answered.

She shouted louder, her voice echoing. "Any relative of Budha Baba?"

Silence.

The NGO girl stood up, her hand holding her bag. "He has no family."

The nurse almost lost her patience, looking at the requisition slip. "What kind of life is this..." she muttered, her hand on her hip.

Before she could finish the sentence, someone from the back of the crowd stepped forward. "I'll give," a voice said.

Everyone turned. It was the flower seller, his hands still carrying the green threads he used to tie marigold garlands.

Immediately, the retired postman came beside him, his khaki bag resting on his hip. "My blood is also O positive. Take mine."

The security guard near the desk raised his hand. "Mine too."

The college student looked confused, shifting his backpack. "I don't know my blood group... but test mine. If it matches, take it."

The auto driver spoke from behind the pillar. "If needed, take mine first. The accident happened near my auto stand. I brought him."

The nurse looked at them. One after another, the people in the corridor kept walking forward, lining up near the desk.

A tea seller, a tailor, a bus conductor, and the old woman who sold jasmine flowers outside the temple—all joined the line. Within two minutes, there were fifteen people standing in a quiet queue.

Nobody asked: **Who is he?**

Nobody asked: **What relation do we have?**

Nobody asked: **Will someone pay for the blood?**

They simply stood there.

The laboratory technician came out of the back room, carrying a tray of syringes. He stopped, counted the queue of fifteen people, and looked at the nurse.

Then he smiled, a real smile. "For the first time," he said, "I have more donors than blood bags."

The nurse looked through the glass pane of the door toward the unconscious old man. She whispered, almost to herself: "Who are you, Baba?"

The answer came from somewhere behind the crowd. It was a familiar voice—quiet, respectful, and dry.

"Ask anyone outside. They'll tell you. But don't ask Baba himself. He never tells."

The crowd slowly turned. An old tea vendor had just arrived, his shirt dusty from the roadside stove. He removed his slippers before standing near the ICU door.

He folded his hands, closed his eyes, and smiled, as though he had just come to visit someone from his own family.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

The casualty door opened again, letting in the cool night breeze and the distant rumble of the city roads. This time, a different doctor entered, younger than the others on duty.

His white coat still looked new, the stiff crease of the laundry iron visible along the sleeves. His stethoscope was carefully placed around his neck, not hanging carelessly like the experienced doctors did.

He walked toward the nurses' station, his shoes clicking softly on the grey floor tiles. He stopped, looking at the unusual crowd that had gathered near the ICU doors.

"What happened?" he asked the receptionist.

The receptionist looked up from her ledger, her glasses sliding down her nose. "Road accident case, sir."

"Anyone serious?"

"An old man. Hit and run near the bypass."

"Name?"

The receptionist checked the register, her finger tracing the fresh ink on the page. "Vikram Ahuja."

The doctor's hand stopped midway while signing the attendance sheet. He looked up slowly, his face going pale.

"What?"

"Vikram Ahuja," she said again.

"Age?"

"Around fifty," the receptionist said, checking the entry.

The doctor stood completely still, the pen still held between his fingers. The receptionist noticed his silence.

"Sir... you know him?"

Adarsh didn't answer. He simply turned and walked toward the ICU doors, his steps slow and heavy, as if he were trying to remember something, or perhaps trying to forget.

Inside the ICU, the old man remained unconscious. The monitors beeped in a dry, regular rhythm, and the saline drips ran quietly into his arm. An oxygen mask covered half his face.

Adarsh stood outside the glass door, staring at the patient. One minute passed, then another, the green lights of the monitors reflecting off his glasses.

The senior nurse came and stood beside him. "Dr. Tripathy... the patient is stable now."

He didn't respond immediately. He looked at the bandaged forehead, the dried blood near the ear, the white beard, and the wrinkled skin.

She studied his face. "You know him?"

He finally spoke, his voice very soft. "I don't know."

"What?"

"I knew someone..." He stopped. "A long time ago."

"Same name?"

"Yes."

"Same person?"

Adarsh looked at the unconscious face, at the old cotton shirt, and at the rubber slippers kept under the stretcher. "I don't know."

The nurse smiled slightly, trying to ease the tension. "Sir... you're a doctor. Check the file."

She handed him the case sheet. He opened it.

Date of birth: 07-07-1977. He calculated quickly. Around fifty. It matched.

*Father's name: **Binay Ahuja**. His hand trembled slightly as he read the name.*

*Address: **Unknown.** Occupation: **Unknown.** Relationship with attendant: **NGO Volunteer.***

He closed the file. He looked again at the old man, then quietly walked away toward the canteen.

The nurse called behind him. "Sir... you know him or not?"

He stopped near the exit, turning back. "I knew someone named Vikram Ahuja," he said. "But that Vikram would never become Budha Baba."

Dr. Adarsh Tripathy walked toward the canteen. He didn't want tea; he simply needed time to think.

The hospital canteen was always the same. Old plastic chairs, stained tables, a ceiling fan rotating slowly, and tea that tasted exactly like yesterday's tea.

He sat in the corner, ordering nothing, and stared at the wall.

Vikram Ahuja. Binay Ahuja. Date of birth 07-07-1977.

Everything matched, yet everything felt wrong. That Vikram wore branded clothes; this Budha Baba wore torn cotton. That Vikram was always surrounded by friends; this old man was brought by an NGO volunteer. That Vikram talked about building companies; this man apparently told crow stories to school children.

The tea seller came to his table anyway, setting down a glass. "Sir... regular?"

Adarsh nodded without looking. The tea arrived. He held the glass, felt the warmth, and remembered.

Twenty-eight years ago. 1995. The year everything began.

He was eighteen then, a first-year MBBS student.

The dissection hall had smelled of formaldehyde, steel trays, and wet lime. A chart of the human skeleton hung on the wall.

There were forty students, ten dissection tables, and complete chaos.

"Where is my scalpel?"

"Who took the forceps?"

"Sir... the specimen is missing a label."

"Careful... careful..."

Someone knocked over a glass jar. There was a burst of laughter, then a professor's scolding, and then the normal noise returned.

Adarsh stood near table seven, alone. His partner hadn't arrived yet. The lab assistant was distributing white aprons, shouting at the class.

"Wear them properly! This is not chemistry. Respect the body. Breakage of instruments will be charged."

Nobody listened completely. Everyone wore their aprons carelessly. Except one boy.

He wore it carefully, tying the strings properly and checking the pockets. Then he quietly walked toward table seven. He looked at Adarsh. "Partner?"

Adarsh nodded.

The boy smiled slightly, extending his hand. "Vicky."

Adarsh shook his hand. "Adarsh."

"Tripathy?" the boy asked.

Adarsh was surprised. "How do you know?"

Vicky pointed at the apron. On the left pocket, someone had stitched a name using blue thread: **Adarsh Tripathy**.

Small letters, neat stitching. It was his mother's handiwork. Adarsh felt a little embarrassed. "My mother..."

Vicky's smile changed. "My mom would have done the same," he said. He paused, his eyes looking at the wall. "But she is no more with me. Lost her when I was young. Never seen her."

Adarsh didn't know what to say. "Sorry" felt too small for the dissection hall.

Vicky's eyes went somewhere else, almost wet. Then he blinked, came back, and picked up the scalpel. He checked its edge against the light, his face going calm. Just like that, the emotion appeared and disappeared.

Adarsh said nothing. They began the dissection—cutting, observing, and labeling.

"Pass the forceps," Vicky said.

"Done?"

"Wait."

Midway through the practical, the lab assistant shouted, "Five minutes remaining!"

Everyone hurried. Mistakes and confusion increased, but Vicky remained calm. He completed every step properly, without any hurry.

Adarsh noticed. This boy was different. He wasn't showing off; he was simply focused.

Professor Khanna walked between the tables. He had a white beard and a reputation for failing half the class. He stopped at table seven.

He read the stitched name aloud. "Adarsh Tripathy."

Adarsh froze, his scalpel suspended.

"Your mother did this?" the professor asked.

"Yes, sir."

A pause. Then the professor smiled. "Good. At least someone's mother believes her son will pass my class."

There was scattered laughter in the hall. The professor moved on.

Vicky whispered, "Saved you."

"Saved me? He announced my name to the whole hall," Adarsh said.

"Better than him announcing you can't hold a scalpel properly," Vicky replied.

It was a fair point.

The bell rang once more just as someone in row three knocked a glass specimen jar off the edge of table four. It didn't break; it simply rolled under the bench with a hollow, rubber-sealed sound and stopped. Everyone looked at it. Nobody moved immediately.

Then someone said, "Who dropped their ring?"

It was Mehta, a boy from table two, patting his pockets in sudden panic. He looked at the bench. He looked at the row of glass waste containers along the wall, the tall ones filled with formaldehyde solution and discarded tissue fragments from two weeks of dissections.

"It slipped off my finger," he said, very quietly.

The ring was visible, if you looked carefully through the thick greenish liquid of the nearest barrel—a thin silver band, resting on the settled layer of pale organic waste at the bottom.

Mehta looked at the barrel. He looked at his hand. He made no move toward it.

"Nobody is putting their hand in that," the boy at table five said, very matter-of-factly. "It is not worth a tetanus shot."

Several heads nodded.

"I'll give you a hundred rupees if you pull it out," somebody offered from the back, with the casual confidence of a person who was quite sure nobody would take the offer.

Vikram set down his forceps, walked to the barrel, pushed his right sleeve up to the elbow, and put his arm in without any particular ceremony. His face didn't change.

The liquid was cold. That was the first thing. The second thing, which nobody in the room had anticipated, was the complete silence that fell over forty students the moment his arm went in past the wrist.

He found the ring by touch, lifted it out, and placed it on the edge of the barrel. Then he walked to the sink, turned the tap on, and washed his arm thoroughly with the carbolic soap kept there, scrubbing between the fingers twice.

Mehta took his ring, said thank you, and cleaned it with the hem of his lab coat.

Vikram dried his hands and went back to table seven.

"You didn't even hesitate," Adarsh said.

"I did," Vikram said, picking up the forceps again. "Just not long enough for anyone to notice."

The bell rang. "Submit your observations."

Everyone rushed toward the professor's desk. Vicky and Adarsh submitted their papers together. Khanna checked them, nodded, and said, "Good."

They removed their aprons, kept them on the rack, and walked out.

Outside the hall, someone called. "Aye... first year."

Four seniors stood near the staircase. Second-year students. It was the ragging season.

Adarsh felt nervous, his throat going dry. Vicky remained calm beside him. The seniors walked closer.

"Name?"

Adarsh answered immediately. "Adarsh Tripathy."

One senior laughed. "Tripathy... Brahmin?"

"Yes."

"Bad luck. General category. No quota, no backup. Pure merit for you, poor fellow."

Everyone laughed. Adarsh said nothing, looking at the steps. Then they turned to Vicky.

"You?"

"Vicky."

The senior blinked. "Vicky?" He turned to the others. "Vicky? That's a dog's name, yaar. My cousin's Pomeranian is called Vicky."

Everyone laughed harder. Vikram's face didn't change.

"Full name," the senior demanded.

A pause. Then Vikram answered. "Vikram Ahuja."

The laughter stopped. "Ahuja... business family?"

Vikram didn't answer.

The senior pressed. "Rich family?"

"I don't know," Vikram said.

"You don't know if your family is rich?" There was laughter again.

Another senior interrupted. "Arre, leave him. Look at his shoes. Nike. Definitely rich."

Vikram looked at his shoes. Then he looked at Adarsh's cheap rubber slippers. He felt uncomfortable—not because of the seniors, but because of the comparison.

One senior stepped closer. "First year riddle. Answer fast."

Vikram waited.

"Which part of the body has no bone, is full of flesh, but is the most sensitive? Nerve endings everywhere."

Silence. Vikram's ears went red. He looked at the ground, refusing to answer.

Adarsh understood the trap. He tried to help, pulling his own tongue out, wiggling it, and pointing at it.

*The seniors burst out laughing. "Oye! Pervert! It's the tongue, man! What were **you** thinking?"*

Vikram's face went from red to redder. "I... I knew that," he said.

"Sure you did," the senior laughed. "Next one. Which part, if you put a finger inside, water comes out?"

Vikram, still flustered, blurted the first thing. "Eye."

The seniors erupted. "Eye? Bro! Should I put my finger in your eye and check? Let's see how much water comes out."

There was laughter loud enough for two floors below. Even Adarsh laughed this time. Vikram's ears stayed red, but then he laughed too—small, reluctant, but real.

The senior turned to Adarsh. "You. Sing a song."

Adarsh's throat closed. He sang two lines, badly.

"Enough. Terrible voice. Go."

They didn't dismiss Vikram. "You. Stay."

*Vikram glanced at Adarsh, giving a small shake of the head. **Go.***

Adarsh walked a few steps, slowed down, and listened.

"Rich boy," the senior was saying. "You think your papa's money matters here?"

"No," Vikram said.

"Good. Remember that."

Adarsh heard footsteps. Vikram caught up with him near the gate. Neither spoke for a while.

Then Adarsh asked, "Your name... Bikram or Vikram?"

"Vikram."

"Why did you say Vicky?"

Vikram smiled, his smile small and tired. "Everyone calls me Vicky. It's easier."

They reached the canteen, ordered tea, and sat on the wooden bench outside. The afternoon sun filtered through the trees, casting shadows on the ground.

The chicken liberation happened four days later. This fact still embarrasses me to recall, but it belongs in the story.

It was Vicky's idea, which means it was the kind of idea that sounds obviously correct at eleven o'clock at night in a hostel room when two people have been studying for six hours on an empty stomach.

The college canteen, which closed at nine, kept five chickens in a wire coop behind the kitchen. They were not pets. Everyone knew what they were for. On Friday nights, the canteen served a chicken curry that was thinned with water and thickened with prayer, which is perhaps why it always tasted exactly the same.

"It is wrong," Vikram said. He was lying on his bed with the Pathology textbook balanced on his chest, looking at the ceiling. He had stopped reading half an hour ago. "They are just sitting there, knowing. Every day they know."

"They are chickens, Vicky."

"They still know," he said, with complete seriousness.

Adarsh put his pen down. He looked at Vikram. Then, unfortunately, he looked at the window. Then at the canteen building, visible from their room as a low, dark shape across the cricket ground.

"We would be expelled," Adarsh said.

"Probably," Vikram agreed.

There was a silence.

"The gate at the back of the canteen doesn't have a lock," Vikram said. "The latch lifts from outside."

Adarsh closed his Pharmacology notes.

They lifted the latch at half past eleven. The five chickens, startled awake, immediately made the kind of sound that five alarmed chickens make at midnight, which is to say, an extremely large sound for a small creature. Adarsh spent most of the operation frozen near the wall, certain that the warden's light would switch on at any moment.

Vikram guided all five through the gate with the calm determination of a man carrying out something he had already made his peace with. The chickens ran. They ran in five different directions, which was probably four more directions than either of them had planned for.

They walked back to the hostel.

In the morning, Adarsh looked across the cricket ground toward the canteen. The canteen cook was at the back gate, looking at the empty wire coop with his arms folded. He looked neither surprised nor particularly upset. He looked like a man who had expected something like this to happen eventually.

By afternoon, two of the chickens had been found crossing the main road and returned to the coop by the gate security guard, who was given five rupees for the trouble.

One was found in the garden of the Registrar's office, pecking serenely at the marigold beds. The Registrar, a thin man who took the college compound very seriously, had it removed with considerable ceremony and some

shouting.

One was sold that same evening by a man from the neighboring village who had found it near the bypass, to a small dhaba on the highway, for eleven rupees.

The fifth was killed by a stray dog near the college wall before noon.

Vikram heard all of this in pieces over the course of the day. He didn't say anything for most of it. At dinner, staring at the same chicken curry that had appeared on schedule regardless of the morning's events, he simply picked up his spoon.

"We made it worse," Adarsh said.

"Yes," Vikram said. He ate the curry. So did Adarsh.

There are some lessons that only register after the fact. Sometimes not even then.

The following weekend, Adarsh went home. His mother had saved enough from the grocery money for his bus fare, and the house smelled of mustard oil and the blue soap she kept wrapped in a cloth at the bottom of the tin trunk, the one she used only on his clothes.

His father, Pandit Tripathy, was a government clerk who had worked in the same municipal records office for twenty-two years. He had the habit of reading the newspaper from the last page forward, because the front page, he said, was always someone else's disaster, while the back page at least had the cricket scores.

He sat across from Adarsh after dinner, his reading glasses pushed to the top of his head. He had that look, the one Adarsh recognized from all the serious conversations of his childhood—forward in the chair, elbows on knees, the way a man sits when he has been waiting for a moment to say something.

"This friend of yours," his father said. "The one you wrote to your mother about. Ahuja."

"Vikram," Adarsh said.

"Ahuja," his father repeated, as though the surname was the point. "Binay Ahuja's son. From Odisha."

"I don't know his father's name."

"I know his father's name," his father said, with the exact tone of a man who has done a small, careful amount of research and is not embarrassed about it. "He is not a small man."

"Vikram's not like that, Baba," Adarsh said. "He wore rubber slippers on the first day. He tied his apron strings properly. He's—"

"I am not saying he is a bad boy," his father said, interrupting gently but firmly. "I am saying be careful. Rich men's sons are easy to like. That is part of the problem."

Adarsh waited.

"They are generous," his father continued, looking down at his folded hands. "They share food, they pay the rickshaw, they don't count the money. And slowly, without anyone meaning for it to happen, you start to feel less, Adarsh. Not because they try to make you feel less. Simply because the comparison is always there."

Quietly. Like a piece of furniture you step around every day without noticing anymore."

"He's not like that."

"You said that already." His father looked at him directly. "I believe you. I'm asking you to watch, anyway. That's all. Watch, and keep your own ground."

Adarsh went back to college two days later. He told Vikram nothing of the conversation.

But he found himself noticing, for the rest of that semester, whether the comparison was ever quietly there.

It wasn't. Or perhaps it was, and Vikram was simply the kind of person who made it invisible. He never paid for the rickshaw without asking first. He never spent in a way that created a gap. When Adarsh's rubber slippers finally split open along the sole in February, Vikram said nothing about it, which was the correct response. His father would not have believed this, but it was true.

Pandit Tripathy's warning was one of those. Adarsh only understood this many years later, sitting in a hospital canteen with a cold glass of tea, thinking about a man he was not sure he recognized anymore.

Dr. Adarsh Tripathy opened his eyes. The hospital canteen returned, the ceiling fan still clicking.

His tea had become cold, and he hadn't taken a single sip.

The tea seller asked, "Sir... shall I change it?"

Adarsh looked at the glass, shook his head, and said, "No."

He stood up and walked back toward the casualty ward. The crowd near the ICU had grown even larger. Someone had brought flowers, and someone else had brought a small basket of fruits. A small child held a hand-drawn greeting card.

The NGO girl still sat on the same chair, holding the walking stick, waiting.

Adarsh stood at a distance, watching everything. Then he slowly walked toward the ICU door.

The nurse saw him. "Sir... did you remember?"

He nodded. "College friend."

"You are sure?"

"Same name. Same father's name. Same date of birth."

"Then why did you say you don't know?"

Adarsh looked through the glass at the unconscious man. "Because..." He stopped. How could he explain? The Vikram he knew was supposed to become something else. Not this.

The nurse waited for the answer. Adarsh simply said, "Because I don't know what happened between then and now."

He walked away, but his mind remained inside the ICU.

That evening, Budha Baba's condition improved. The blood transfusion was completed, the bleeding stopped, and his vitals became stable.

The senior doctor allowed one visitor. The NGO girl immediately stood up and entered the ICU.

She stood beside the bed, looking at the old man. His eyes remained closed, but his breathing had become normal. She didn't say anything; she simply kept her hand on his, very softly, as though reassuring herself he was still alive.

After two minutes, she quietly left.

Outside, the entire crowd looked at her, waiting for news. She smiled. "He is better."

There was a wave of relief. Immediately, the little boy shouted, "Baba will tell the crow story now!"

Everyone smiled, even the serious-looking security guard.

The NGO girl sat back on her chair. This time, she finally noticed her own injury. Blood had dried on her elbow, her sleeve was torn, and she hadn't even cleaned it.

A nurse came with cotton and Dettol. "Let me see."

The girl hesitated.

The nurse understood. "I know. AIDS. I'll be careful." She cleaned the wound and applied a bandage. "You should have treated this first."

The girl smiled. "Baba was more important."

"Why?"

The girl looked toward the ICU. "Because... he taught me that life is bigger than diseases."

The nurse didn't understand completely, but she didn't ask further.

Dr. Adarsh Tripathy completed his duty at 8 PM. He signed the register and removed his white coat, but he didn't leave immediately. He walked back toward the ICU one more time.

The crowd had reduced slightly, but the NGO girl still remained. He stood beside her.

She looked up. "Doctor sahib... he will recover, right?"

Adarsh nodded. "He will."

"When can we take him home?"

"A few days."

She nodded, relieved.

Adarsh hesitated, then asked, "You know him since long?"

"Three years."

"How did you meet him?"

She smiled. "He came to our NGO. Said he wanted to teach children. No salary. Just time pass."

Adarsh felt strange hearing this. Vikram Ahuja, the son of Binay Ahuja, teaching children for "time pass." Something didn't fit.

"What does he teach?"

"Everything. Maths. Science. Stories. Life."

"Where does he live?"

"Near the NGO. A small room."

"Alone?"

"Yes."

"No family?"

The girl thought for a moment. "Baba never talks about family."

Adarsh wanted to ask more, but he stopped. Instead, he asked something else. "What is your name?"

"Ananya."

"You work in the NGO?"

"Yes. HIV awareness program."

Adarsh understood why she had the virus—it was probably contracted during her own struggle before she found the shelter. "Thank you for bringing him here."

Ananya smiled. "I should thank him. He brought me here three years ago. Same hospital. Different reason."

Adarsh waited.

"When I got my HIV report," she said, her voice dropping. "I tried to end my life. Pills. Hospital. Stomach wash. Baba was the only one who visited me. Every single day. Until I walked out alive."

She looked at Adarsh. "Today... I returned the favor."

Adarsh said nothing. He simply nodded, his hand going to his jacket pocket, his fingers finding his keys for no particular reason, not knowing what else to do with them. Then he quietly left.

Outside the hospital, the night had become completely dark. Auto rickshaws honked, street vendors shouted, and normal city life went on.

Adarsh stood near the gate, trying to process everything.

Vikram Ahuja. Budha Baba. Same person. Different life. What happened?

He knew only one thing clearly: tomorrow, when Vikram woke up, he would ask—not as a doctor, but as an old friend.

Back in the ICU, around 11 PM, the monitor beeped differently. The duty nurse checked his vitals and smiled. The patient was waking up.

She informed the senior doctor, who came immediately. "Good. Consciousness returning. Keep monitoring."

Around 11:30 PM, the old man's eyes slowly opened. First confused, then focused. He saw the white ceiling, smelled the hospital air, and heard the beeping machines.

He tried to remember. The road. The auto. The sudden crash. The children screaming. Ananya's voice. Then darkness.

He tried to speak, but his throat was dry.

The nurse came closer. "Baba... you are in the hospital. Don't worry. You are safe now."

He blinked, trying to understand, and drank a few drops of water she offered.

"Ananya?" he whispered.

"Outside. Waiting."

He tried to sit up, but the nurse held his shoulder gently. "Careful, Baba."

He lay back, closing his eyes again, but this time he was just tired, very tired.

The nurse stepped out and told Ananya, "He woke up. Asked for you."

Ananya smiled, tears coming suddenly. She didn't enter the ICU; she simply folded her hands toward the door, whispering, "Thank you."

That night, Dr. Adarsh couldn't sleep. He kept thinking of the pathology textbook, the blue name stitched on the white apron, and their first meeting.

What happened after college? Where did he go? Why didn't they stay in touch? How did Vikram become Budha Baba?

Questions without answers. He knew tomorrow he would get some answers, but he also knew some questions would remain forever.

[End of Part 3]

CHAPTER II: THE BLUE COLLAR

PART 1

Winter, 1996/97. Six months had passed since they entered their second year of MBBS.

The registrar's office queue moved the way government queues always move—at the pace of a man who has all the time in the world because he is not the one waiting.

Vikram and Adarsh had been standing in it for forty minutes to submit a leave application form, a single-page document that required three signatures, two countersignatures, and, apparently, one office seal that was currently resting on the desk of a peon who had stepped out for chai and not yet returned.

Adarsh stood with his back against the compound wall, reading the same paragraph of Pharmacology for the third time. Vikram stood looking at the street outside the campus gate, doing nothing in particular.

A stray dog sat on the pavement just beyond the iron gate. It was a thin, short-haired dog, the kind that lives by the logic of government buildings—present every day, fed by no one, belonging to everyone in the way that things no one owns belong to everyone and to no one simultaneously. It was shivering, though not dramatically. A small, continuous tremble, as if its body had long ago accepted shivering as its default setting.

Vikram looked at it for some time.

Then he walked out of the gate and down the lane to the small general store near the bus stand. He came back five minutes later carrying a packet of cream biscuits—the expensive kind with the embossed pattern on the top, not the plain glucose biscuits that cost two rupees.

"You left the queue," Adarsh said.

Vikram didn't respond to this. He opened the packet, crouched beside the gate pillar, and placed the biscuits on the flat stone near the dog's feet, half a dozen of them, arranged in a loose row.

The dog looked at the biscuits.

It sniffed once, deliberately, in the formal way dogs examine things they have already decided about. Then it turned its head, walked three paces to the left, and began chewing on a torn plastic bag that had come to rest against the drainage ditch. Inside the bag, from what Adarsh could see from the gate, were some fish bones and a slick of old gravy.

The biscuits sat on the stone, untouched.

Vikram stood up, looked at the dog for a moment, and walked back to the queue.

He said nothing about it. He picked up his Pathology textbook and resumed reading exactly where he had stopped, without any visible change in expression.

Adarsh looked at the biscuits, then at the dog, then at Vikram.

"It didn't want them," he said.

"I know," Vikram said.

"Then why buy the expensive ones?"

Vikram kept his eyes on his book. "Because the cheap ones would have been for me," he said. "The expensive ones were for it."

Adarsh thought about this for the rest of the afternoon and couldn't quite find the end of it.

It was a cold evening, the kind where the mist rolls off the university sports ground and hangs thick around the hostel corridors. Adarsh walked down the second-floor passageway, his jacket zipped up, and knocked on the door of room twenty-four.

No answer came. He waited, then pushed the wooden door open.

The room was empty. A single table lamp was lit, casting a circle of yellow light over the desk. On the desk lay the thick Pathology textbook, open to chapter three, the lines half-underlined in blue ink that had ended mid-sentence.

Beside the book was a steel tumbler, full of cold tea. Vikram never left his tea unfinished; not once in the six months they had shared the room had Adarsh seen him leave a cup half-drunk.

Adarsh noticed that small detail before he noticed anything else. It felt like a small crack in the room's normal order.

Adarsh stepped back into the corridor. The passage was quiet, the sound of television news echoing from the common room downstairs.

He walked down toward the warden's office at the end of the block. There was only one telephone in the entire hostel—a heavy, black rotary dial phone chained to the brick wall outside the warden's window.

Usually, there was a long line of students waiting for their turn, clutching coins and shivering in their sweaters. But tonight, the corridor was empty.

Only Vikram stood there, his back to the staircase. He was holding the thick receiver to his ear, his head tilted down.

He wasn't speaking; he was just listening. Adarsh slowed his steps, stopping near the concrete pillar. There was something in the way Vikram stood—his shoulders too rigid, his head bent too low.

"...when?" Vikram's voice was barely a whisper.

The telephone line crackled loudly, a distance-heavy static that filled the quiet corridor. It was a trunk call, routed through two exchanges in Cuttack and Bhubaneswar. The operator's voice cut in once—"Connected, go ahead"—followed by a loud pop and more crackles.

"...how bad?" Vikram asked. The line went dead mid-sentence, the dial tone returning in a flat, metallic hum.

Vikram stood there for a long time, the receiver still pressed to his ear, listening to the empty tone. Then, his fingers trembling slightly, he inserted his finger into the metal dial and spun it again.

He waited, his chest rising and falling slowly. The connection clicked through.

"...say it again," Vikram said, his voice flat. He listened to the answer for a few seconds. "I'm coming. Tonight."

He placed the receiver back on its iron hook. He didn't move; he simply stood there, staring at the grey plaster of the wall in front of him.

The single light bulb hanging above the phone flickered once, buzzing softly in the cold air, then steadied again. Adarsh walked over, his shoes making a loud sound on the concrete.

"Vicky?"

No response.

"Vicky," Adarsh said, placing a hand on his shoulder.

Vikram turned around slowly. Adarsh had never seen his face look like that. It wasn't sad or tearful; it was completely emptied of expression, like a room where the furniture had been suddenly cleared out.

"Papa," Vikram said. He stopped there, his mouth staying slightly open.

Adarsh waited, his hand still on Vikram's shoulder.

"They said liver," Vikram continued, his voice thin. "Then the doctor said a word. I made him repeat it twice because the line was bad."

"What word?"

"Decompensated," Vikram said.

Adarsh felt his own stomach drop. He knew the word; they had read it only two days ago in Pathology, in the chapter that neither of them had finished before the exams.

"That doesn't mean—" Adarsh started.

"I know what it means and what it doesn't," Vikram said, his voice sharp and flat. "It means nobody can tell me yet if he has one bad month or five good years. Uncle just kept saying, 'We'll see, we'll see.' I've never heard a doctor sound more useless."

Adarsh didn't know what to say. Medical college teaches you the names of diseases and the dosage of drugs, but nobody teaches you what to say to a friend whose father is dying.

"I need to go home," Vikram said, his eyes focusing on the staircase.

"I'll come with you to the station—"

"No," Vikram said, too fast. Then he looked at Adarsh and softened his tone. "No. Stay here. The semester exams are too close. I'll go alone."

"Vicky, this isn't about exams—"

"I know what it's about," Vikram said, his voice rising, then dropping immediately. "Sorry. I just need to move."

Adarsh said nothing. He followed Vikram back to room twenty-four.

Vikram pulled a blue canvas bag from under his bed and started throwing things in—two shirts, a pair of trousers, some woolen socks. His hand went to the wooden shelf, stopping at the dissection kit.

The small steel instruments were wrapped in a green velvet cloth, the ones he had kept wound tight and oiled since their first dissection class. He picked it up, hesitated, and then put it back exactly where it was, like leaving a marker for something to return to.

Then he looked at the open Pathology book on the desk. He held it for a second, his fingers touching the blue underlines, then closed it and left it on the table. He didn't pack it.

Adarsh noticed, but said nothing. Vikram zipped the canvas bag, the sound of the plastic teeth loud in the quiet room.

He looked around the room once, checking the shelves and the desk, as if verifying he wasn't forgetting anything. But he was forgetting nothing; he was leaving everything.

"There's a passenger train at eleven," Vikram said, looking at the alarm clock on the desk. "I'll make it if I leave now."

Adarsh walked him down the stairs and out to the hostel gate. The night had settled fully, the campus roads dark under the eucalyptus trees.

Crickets chirped somewhere in the bushes. A stray dog followed them halfway down the gravel path, then lost interest and curled up under a bench.

At the gate, Vikram stopped and turned to Adarsh. "If I don't come back for the practical exam next week..."

"You'll come back," Adarsh said.

"If I don't..."

"Vicky," Adarsh said, his voice firm.

Vikram exhaled, his breath turning to white mist in the cold air. "Papa always wanted a doctor in the family. He used to tell the relatives at every wedding, 'My son will wear the white coat.' Proudly. Like it was already done."

He looked down at his hands. "I don't think that's happening now."

"Don't decide anything tonight, Vicky. Just go home first."

"I'm not deciding," Vikram said. "I'm just telling you what I already know."

A cycle rickshaw turned in from the main road, its single headlight sweeping across the gate. Vikram waved his hand. The rickshaw stopped, the driver looking at the canvas bag.

Vikram picked up his bag. "Tell the professor... family emergency. I'll write a letter when I know more."

"Vicky—"

He was already climbing onto the rickshaw. He half-turned back, the yellow light of the gate lamp on his face. "Thanks for not asking if I'm okay."

The rickshaw pulled away, the driver's feet working the pedals slowly. The red tail-light shrank down the dark road, disappearing behind the trees.

Adarsh stood at the gate for a long time, the cold wind biting his neck. Then he walked back to room twenty-four.

The door was still open, the table lamp still lit. He walked to the desk, picked up the Pathology textbook, closed it, and kept it safely inside the wooden cupboard.

Vikram never came back for the practical exam. He didn't return for the next semester, or the one after that.

His name stayed on the college register for one more year, a dry line of black ink, until it was struck off by the administration. Nobody in the hostel talked about it for long; a new batch arrived, new names occupied the rooms, and new rumors replaced the old ones.

Adarsh kept the Pathology textbook. Years later, while packing his bags to leave the hostel after graduation, he found it at the back of the cupboard.

The blue ink lines were still there, ending mid-sentence, the dust thick on the cover. He didn't know where to send it; he had never found out Vikram's address in Cuttack.

He kept it anyway. Every year, around the same winter week, he would open his cupboard and find the book still there, the dust a little thicker.

He never asked himself why he hadn't thrown it out. He just closed the cupboard door again, leaving it in the dark.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

The hospital corridor smelled of Dettol, floor bleach, and overcooked rice from the visitors' canteen downstairs. Vikram found his father's room by counting the doors along the corridor, refusing to ask the busy nurses at the main station.

His father was not sitting up in bed, reading files or shouting commands at the office staff. That version of the scene had existed only in the imaginations Vikram had built on the overnight passenger train from college.

The real scene: Binay Ahuja lay propped on two flat, yellowed pillows, his skin having gone the dull color of weak tea. A saline tube was taped crookedly into the back of his right hand, the plastic bag dripping slowly above the iron bedframe.

He was awake, his eyes fixed on the wooden door.

"You came," Binay said, his voice dry and raspy. It was not a question.

"Papa," Vikram said, standing near the foot of the bed.

"Sit."

Vikram sat on the low wooden stool beside the bedside cabinet. For a long time, neither of them said the thing that needed saying; instead, they said the small, empty things that fill the space before it.

"Rohan ate?" Binay asked, looking toward the window.

"I don't know, Papa. I came straight from the station."

"Someone should check on him. He's at home."

"I'll check," Vikram said.

"Sit first," Binay said, his hand twitching slightly on the sheet.

Vikram sat back down. A young resident doctor came in, flipped the cardboard chart hanging from the bed rail, and spoke.

He used words like **portal hypertension** and **we'll monitor** and **let's see how he responds to the diuretics** in the calm, rehearsed tone doctors use when they don't yet know which sentence they'll have to say next week.

Vikram, now six months into his second year of medicine, understood exactly enough of the words to know that "not knowing" was the actual diagnosis.

The resident doctor left, his stethoscope tapping against his hip. Binay watched him go, his eyes narrowing slightly.

"He talks like your college professors," Binay said, his lips thin. "Confident about being unsure."

"That's the job, Papa. Medicine is like that sometimes."

"It was going to be your job too."

Vikram said nothing. He looked at the white walls, where the paint had started peeling near the ceiling fan.

"I told Sharma-ji at the club last year," Binay said, his voice dropping. "'My son, wait and watch, one day he will be a big doctor.' I said it like the degree was already sitting in my pocket. Like a pocket watch."

He looked at the saline line in his own hand, studying the tape as if it belonged to someone else. "Seems fate had a different item in that pocket."

"Papa, don't talk like that—"

"I'm not being dramatic, Vikram. I'm being accurate," Binay said.

A heavy silence settled in the room, carrying the weight of unsaid things. Then Binay did something Vikram had never expected; he looked almost embarrassed, his eyes shifting away from his son's face.

"I have to ask you something," Binay said, "and I don't like asking it."

"Ask, Papa."

"Can you stay here for some weeks? Just to look after things at the office. Nothing big. Just sign what Pradhan-babu tells you to sign."

Binay coughed, his hand going to his side. "Rohan is sixteen, still in school. He can't be at the plant every day, and the distributors are starting to make noise."

"Some weeks," Vikram repeated, his throat dry.

"That's all I'm asking," Binay said, closing his eyes.

It did not feel like all he was asking. It felt like the first sentence of something much longer, spoken deliberately small so that it could be agreed to without fear.

Vikram said yes anyway. What else does a nineteen-year-old say to a father with a tube taped to his hand and skin the color of weak tea.

Pradhan-babu turned out to be sixty-one years old, wore the same brown wool cardigan every day regardless of the heat, and had worked for Binay Ahuja since before Vikram was born.

His office was a single small room with one ceiling fan missing a blade, which made the whole ceiling shake, and a typewriter that jammed every time he hit the letter 'M'.

"Sign here, sign here, and here," Pradhan-babu told Vikram on the first morning. He slid three thick green ledgers across the wooden desk.

Vikram took the pen and signed his name quickly.

"Not like that," Pradhan-babu said, pointing with a ruler.

"Like what?"

"Full signature. Vikram Ahuja. Not initials. The bank won't accept initials from a new signatory on the account."

Vikram signed again, slower this time. The letters came out wrong-sized and shaky, a schoolboy's handwriting trying to look official.

Pradhan-babu watched him do it twice more before the signature looked acceptable. He didn't comment; he just took the ledgers back, blew the dust off the edges, and refiled them in the steel cabinet.

At noon, a factory supervisor from the malt unit came to the office, twisting his cloth cap in both hands, waiting to speak to "Ahuja Sahib."

Vikram stood up to greet him properly, the way he had been taught to greet a senior doctor doing rounds in the hospital. "Sir," Vikram said, before he could stop himself.

The supervisor blinked, his face confused. He looked behind him to check who Vikram was addressing, but nobody was there.

Pradhan-babu spoke from his desk, without looking up from his typewriter. "You're Ahuja Sahib now, Vikram. People say sir to you. Not the other way."

The typewriter jammed at that exact moment. The 'M' key locked mid-stroke, the carriage refusing to advance.

Pradhan-babu picked up his wooden ruler without any change in expression, tapped the side of the typewriter mechanism twice—not hard, but with the precision of a man who has found the exact spot—blew into the small space between the keys, and pressed the 'M' twice more to confirm it had returned to service.

Then he resumed typing, exactly where he had stopped, as if this had not happened.

Vikram felt his ears go warm, the exact same warmth he had felt on the staircase at college when the seniors had laughed at his name. He stood up straight, clearing his throat.

"Yes," Vikram said to the supervisor, trying to keep his voice steady. "Tell me. What's the problem at the malt unit?"

It was better. Not good, but better.

Some weeks became six weeks. Six weeks became a semester he didn't return for.

Binay Ahuja came home from the hospital thinner than before and walking slower, but he was home. The crisis, whatever it truly was, had loosened its grip without fully letting go.

His father never again mentioned the boy who was going to wear a white coat. Vikram never again mentioned the exams he had missed, or the ones after that.

The Pathology textbook stayed behind in the hostel cupboard two hundred kilometers away, in room twenty-four, where neither of them thought about it often.

The signature got better and faster. The word "sir" stopped catching in Vikram's throat.

Within a year, nobody in that dusty office remembered that he had ever hesitated at the desk. Vikram remembered, but he just stopped mentioning it to anyone.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

By twenty-six, Vikram's name appeared in a major business magazine's "Ones to Watch" list, accompanied by a black-and-white photograph that made him look older than he was.

By twenty-eight, the same magazine dropped the word "Watch" and simply placed his name among the top young industrialist profiles in the country.

By twenty-nine, three years running, a Forbes list carried him too. He was always placed somewhere in the lower half, and they always misspelled Ahuja as "Ahluja" in at least one edition, which annoyed Pradhan-babu far more than it ever annoyed Vikram.

None of this success had happened in the South. Not one factory, not one office, not a single storage unit had been built below the Godavari River.

That section of his corporate map stayed blank on purpose. Or, more honestly, it was kept blank out of a quiet caution that nobody in the boardrooms had yet dared to challenge him on.

The state government's new liquor licensing policy arrived like most government policies do. It was a rumor two months before it was a rule, and a full-blown crisis the week after it was officially signed.

The policy brought new licensing slabs, higher import duties, and a state minister who had never visited a distillery in his life explaining distillery economics on television with great confidence.

Pradhan-babu, who was now wearing a second woolen cardigan for winter, aged but refusing to retire, laid the gazette on Vikram's desk. "Sir, if this policy stands as it is drafted, we will lose the Odisha license by March. The margins won't hold."

"Then it won't stand as drafted," Vikram said, without looking up from the figures.

"You are planning to fight the state government in court?"

"I am going to make sure the state government understands what four thousand factory jobs look like on paper before they sign the final draft," Vikram said.

It took eleven months of constant travel, coordination with two national industry associations, one strategically timed press conference in the capital, and a compromise that nobody loved equally.

In the end, the license survived. Vikram didn't celebrate; he went home, ate a quiet dinner alone, and read the fine print of the amended policy twice, the way some men reread a letter from someone they miss.

Ira Sen came to interview him for that same press conference. She worked for the business desk of a mid-size newspaper with ambitions of becoming a national daily.

She asked sharper, colder questions than the journalists from the bigger papers.

"Everyone talks about the license survival, Mr. Ahuja," she said, her pen hovering over her notepad. "But nobody is asking what it cost you personally to fight this for eleven months."

Nobody had asked him that in the last year. He looked at her, studying her face. "Is that an interview question?"

"No," she said, closing her notepad. "That one is just for me."

He liked that she said it. The second interview never officially happened; she came back to the office two days later to "fact-check one quote" and stayed for dinner instead, and neither of them ever filed that particular follow-up story.

She had a way of sitting across a table that made boardrooms feel like a different, distant profession. She would rest her elbows on the dark wood, her chin low over folded hands, watching him the way she watched a source who was about to say something he shouldn't.

"You are doing it again," he told her once as they sat in a quiet cabin.

"Doing what?"

"Interviewing me. Off the record."

"Everything is off the record with you, Vikram," she said, smiling. "Until you decide otherwise."

He decided otherwise, slowly, over the course of that autumn.

Their first evening alone lasted until neither of them noticed that the driver had circled the block four times, waiting for a telephone call that never came.

Streetlight through the car window. Her hand finding the back of his neck, warm and slow, the way she was when she had finished the day's edits.

It was raining when they reached her apartment door. She didn't speak; she took his keys, opened the door, and pulled him inside by his wet collar.

Her room smelled of old newsprint and jasmine agarbatti. She worked his tie loose before either of them had said a word, her fingers warm against his collarbone.

Some nights they sat on the floor, her head resting against his chest, the city traffic outside dimming to a low hum. She would talk about a headline that had been cut, or the price of paper in Calcutta, and Vikram would listen, holding his glass of water, his shoulders dropping an inch on their own.

That was the thing the ledger never gave him. Silence that asked for nothing back.

Other nights were faster—her hand tracing his neck in the dark, his mouth finding her shoulder, the dry, clean heat of her skin. They didn't talk about how long it would last. In their profession, you didn't ask for a guarantee before you read the story.

He never told Pradhan-babu why he started leaving the office by eight most evenings. He never told Rohan why he had started smiling at his phone at odd hours, a habit their father would have found, if he had lived to see it, both endearing and faintly ridiculous.

He gave her, without her asking twice, a supplementary card on his bank account. It was the kind of gesture rich men make when they want love to feel like less of a transaction, and it always, invisibly, becomes one anyway.

That October, during the Durga Puja week, she told him she had a special assignment.

"Delhi," she said, packing a small suitcase. "Festive coverage. Three days."

"Take the office car to the airport," Vikram said.

"I'll take a regular cab, don't fuss," she said.

He fussed anyway. He ordered a car for her from the office, complete with a driver, and insisted until she agreed.

She left for the airport, she said, on Tuesday morning.

On Wednesday afternoon, Vikram's phone buzzed once on his desk. It was a transaction alert, the bank's dry little automated message that he usually cleared without reading.

Rs. 340 debited — Café Coffee Day, Salt Lake, near the press building.

He looked at the screen twice, his brow furrowing. Salt Lake was eleven kilometers from the airport, and considerably farther from Delhi.

He almost called her. Then he thought: the flight must have been delayed, she is probably killing time near the office before catching a later connection. There was no need to panic.

He had, that exact week, been meaning to give her something. It was a car of her own—not an office-arranged vehicle, but hers. A cream-colored sedan, the keys in his pocket, a small red ribbon still tied in the boot because he hadn't decided yet whether that was too much or exactly enough.

He thought: if she is still in the city, let me surprise her at the office before she leaves. He drove the cream-colored car there himself, leaving his driver behind.

The building security guard let him through the gate without question. His face, by then, opened most doors in the city without the need to announce a name.

Her cabin was on the second floor of the editorial block, glass-walled on one side, with the plastic blinds pulled half-down. The door was ajar.

He didn't knock. He had never needed to before.

He pushed the door open, expecting to see her at her desk, phone to her ear, ready to be surprised by the keys.

What he saw instead took his mind a full two seconds longer to process than it should have. It was the kind of two seconds where the body understands the truth before the brain agrees to accept it.

Her blouse, unbuttoned wrong, hung off her left shoulder.

A man's leather belt lay uncoiled on the floor near the leg of the desk. Rajeev, a junior sub-editor, someone Vikram had shaken hands with twice at office parties and forgotten both times, was leaning over her.

Underwear—hers, his—was scattered on the carpet without any pretense of having been placed rather than dropped in a hurry. Neither of them heard the door open.

For one full second, nobody in that room moved. Vikram didn't shout. He didn't ask a single question that he already had every answer to.

He slowly stepped back into the corridor. He closed the door as quietly as he had opened it. If anything, he closed it even quieter, as though the one courtesy left to give them was his silence.

Downstairs, the cream-colored car sat exactly where he had parked it near the entrance, the red ribbon still tied in the boot. Vikram stood beside it for perhaps a minute, the hot afternoon sun beating down on his face.

Nobody watching him would have called the expression on his face rage. It looked, if anything, like simple arithmetic—a accountant solving one final sum before closing the ledger.

He picked up a fist-sized stone from the decorative flowerbed lining the main entrance. He didn't swing it in a fury.

He brought it down once, deliberately, on the center of the windshield, the glass spiderwebbing instantly. Then he struck it once more on the bonnet, denting the cream paint he had chosen himself two weeks ago after looking at eleven color swatches with an attention to detail he never gave his own wardrobe.

He set the stone down on the driver's seat, almost politely, the way you would return a book you had borrowed.

He got into his own car, started the engine, and drove away. He left the gift exactly where it stood—wrecked, ribboned, and paid for.

Ira came down the stairs forty minutes later, adjusting her earring, laughing at something Rajeev had said in the lift. She stopped dead at the sight of the car.

The glass lay scattered across the concrete pavement, catching the harsh glare of the streetlights.

The security guard, an older man named Naresh who had opened that gate for Vikram eleven times that year without ever learning his last name, stepped forward.

"Madam," the guard said, his voice hesitant. "Vikram sir came. He brought this car for you. He left it there, then he left in anger."

Ira said nothing for a long moment, her hand going to her throat.

Rajeev, standing beside her, asked the question that everyone in that story except Vikram always asks too late. "Did he see us?"

Nobody answered him. Ira was still looking at the red ribbon, soaked now from where the radiator had leaked out beneath the dented hood, still tied in a bow that nobody would ever get to undo.

She reached out and touched it once, her fingers just grazing the wet cloth. Then she walked away.

The cream car stayed where it was for three days.

Vikram's driver, who heard what had happened from the security guard Naresh, was instructed by the accounts office to arrange its recovery. There was a telephone call to the insurance company, a form was dispatched by registered post, and a surveyor's visit was booked for the following Thursday.

Nobody told the vegetable vendors on the pavement outside.

By the second morning, three vendors from the roadside market that ran along the outer wall of the press building had discovered that the flat metal hood of the cream car, which was wide, horizontal, and caught the sun from eight in the morning onward, was ideal for drying red chillies.

The surveyor arrived on Thursday to find the bonnet spread thick with a deep red layer of chillies, laid out in careful, overlapping rows and smelling strongly of the Andhra sun. A thin woman in a yellow sari was turning them with a stick, her brass bangles clicking with each pass.

She looked at the surveyor with the calm of someone engaged in obvious, purposeful work.

The surveyor made a note in his form, took a photograph, and wrote: **vehicle in use, recovery delayed**. He filed the claim on Friday. The car was eventually towed away ten days after the incident, the cream paint permanently stained along the dent in a crescent of dark red dust.

Naresh, the security guard, told this story to anyone who asked about the car. He told it as a kind of ending, the only one available, because the other ending—the red ribbon, the shattered glass, Vikram's face when he left—was the kind nobody wanted to finish.

He never spoke her name again. He didn't mention it to Pradhan-babu, who never asked, nor to Rohan, who heard a version of the story third-hand years later and never brought it up.

The bank card was cancelled the next morning—a five-minute telephone call, no note, no message.

[End of Part 3]

PART 4

After the night downstairs at the press building, Vikram stopped explaining his evenings to anyone.

Pradhan-babu noticed that the office lights stayed on much later, the yellow glow from the corner windows shining onto the empty courtyard long after the clerks had gone home.

Rohan noticed that his brother had stopped mentioning names of any kind, whether friends or business associates. It was the way a man stops walking near a particular street corner after he has twisted his ankle in a pothole there once.

Neither of them said anything. Work absorbed what the quiet evenings used to hold.

By thirty, the company's Odisha operations ran themselves well enough that Pradhan-babu, who was now nearing his retirement in earnest, told anyone who asked: "Ahuja Sahib could run this entire state with his eyes closed. Which is a problem, because a man needs something to keep his eyes open for."

Nobody quite understood what the old manager meant by that, except Vikram.

The telephone call came on a hot Tuesday afternoon. This time, it was not from his uncle, but from the family doctor directly, using the flat, unhesitating tone doctors use only when there is nothing left to soften.

"Mr. Ahuja, I won't use words like 'let's see' this time," the doctor said. "Your father's liver has failed past the point where monitoring or hope means anything. We are looking at weeks. Possibly a few months, if he is very fortunate and very careful."

Ten years had passed since the first scare in the Shobhabazar clinic. Ten years of business lists and licenses, and this time the sentence didn't leave any doors open.

Vikram sat with the heavy receiver still pressed against his ear long after the doctor had disconnected. The dial tone hummed in the quiet office, the particular silence of a fact that has stopped being negotiable.

Binay Ahuja insisted on attending the scheduled board meeting anyway, refusing to remain in his bed.

"If I am going, Vikram," he said as they rode in the back of the car, "I am going having placed you in that Chairman's chair myself. I will not leave it for the lawyers and the vultures to argue over after I am in the ground."

The boardroom held twelve men that morning. They sat around the same long teak table Vikram had once sat beside as a teenager, signing ledgers Pradhan-babu slid across to him.

Except now, three of the twelve directors stood up slightly straighter when he entered the room, and he had stopped noticing exactly when that shift had started happening.

Binay sat at the head of the table. He was thinner than the normal frailty of ten quiet years should account for; this was a new, sharper kind of thinness that had a definite deadline attached to it.

The agenda on the paper in front of them was simple: the South India expansion.

It meant two new states, three major cities, a completely different tax structure, and a market that had ignored the Ahuja brand for three generations because the family had never once tried to cross the river.

Sinha, silver-haired and sharp-eyed, who had argued for Vikram's seat on this board a decade ago when the others hesitated, spoke first. "We need a younger perspective for a market like this. Someone who is unafraid of an unfamiliar map and willing to travel."

Reddy, older still, sat with his arms folded across his chest. He hadn't looked at Vikram once since the meeting began. "South India needs experience, Sinha. Not a fresh graduate's confidence."

"He has run our daily operations here for ten years," Sinha said, tapping his pen on the agenda.

"Here," Reddy said. He finally turned to face Vikram directly, his expression not unkind, but completely certain.

"Here, where the ground was already laid by his father, and every supplier already knew the Ahuja name before Vikram even walked into the room. South India will not extend him that courtesy. Nobody down there has heard of us, and nobody down there owes us patience or trust."

He looked at Vikram properly, his eyes narrowing. "What do you know about building something that nobody is required to trust yet?"

The room went quiet, the only sound being the soft whir of the air conditioner.

*Vikram thought of a hostel corridor telephone, a pathology textbook left unopened in a friend's cupboard, and a factory supervisor twisting his cap while saying **sir** to a nineteen-year-old who didn't yet know how to sign a bank document.*

He thought of the eleven months he had spent fighting a liquor licensing policy that nobody else in this room had lost sleep over. He thought of a stone, a shattered windshield, and how nobody in this room knew about that either.

Ten years of things that nobody in this boardroom had witnessed, and here was Reddy, entirely sincerely, asking what he knew about being unproven.

"Nothing," Vikram said finally, his voice calm. "I know nothing about it yet."

Reddy almost smiled, as if the young man's honesty confirmed his own thoughts. "Exactly my point."

"But I know what it costs to become known somewhere new," Vikram continued, looking Reddy in the eye. "I've paid that particular bill once already. I didn't enjoy it. But I would like the chance to pay it again, somewhere it might actually build something instead of just costing me my peace."

Nobody in the room understood the second sentence, and Vikram didn't bother to explain it to them.

Reddy studied him for a moment longer. "Still," he said, "it is a kid taking on a grown man's risk."

Sinha bristled. "Every leader starts somewhere, Reddy. We can't keep him in Odisha forever."

"He didn't start today," Reddy said. "That is exactly my worry. He has been quietly competent in a market that forgives him everything. I don't know yet if he is competent in a market that won't."

Binay, from the head of the table, raised one thin, trembling hand before the argument could widen between the directors.

"Meeting adjourned," Binay said. His voice cost him a great deal of effort to produce, audible in the short, raspy breath that followed it.

"We will resume tomorrow morning, once everyone in this room remembers that we have less time than we think. Some of us considerably less than others."

The chairs scraped back against the polished floor. Each man reached for his briefcase handle before he stood, the instinctive grip of someone steadying himself. The twelve of them filed out without speaking, each one carrying the news home in his own chest.

Vikram remained seated at the long table, looking at the empty chairs, while Reddy's question still sat in the air like smoke that hadn't found a window yet.

[End of Part 4]

PART 5

The boardroom emptied out slowly, the way rooms do when everyone in them is pretending not to be in a hurry.

Vikram stood at the wide glass window after the last mahogany chair had scraped back against the carpet. He kept his hands in his pockets, looking down at the sprawling city skyline that his father's name had built, one clumsy signature at a time, over thirty years.

He didn't hear Binay come back into the room, his footsteps muffled by the thick carpet.

"They don't believe you can do it," Binay said, his voice coming from behind the leather armchair.

Vikram didn't turn around. "I have been doing it for ten years, Papa, and nobody in that room seemed to notice."

Binay came to stand beside him at the window, his movements slower than they used to be. One of his thin hands briefly found the wooden frame of the glass pane for balance, before he let go of it again, unwilling to be seen needing support.

"That is the wrong complaint, Vikram," the old man said.

"What's the right one?"

"The question was never whether they noticed," Binay said, his eyes scanning the city.

There was a long pause, so long that Vikram finally turned his head to look at him. His father's profile looked sharp and dark against the afternoon light.

"The question is whether you will do it again," Binay said, looking at his son. "Somewhere nobody hands you the ground already prepared. Somewhere you are the kid Reddy thinks you are, because for one honest minute, you actually will be."

Vikram looked back at the glass. The city lights outside had started to flicker on, turning the window into a soft double exposure.

The boardroom behind him—the long mahogany table, the empty leather chairs, the portrait of his grandfather—was faintly ghosted over the dusty skyline in front of him.

Somewhere in the overlap of the glass, for just a blink, the reflection looking back at him wasn't a thirty-year-old industrialist in a tailored suit.

It was thinner. Younger. A first-year student with a hostel corridor phone still warm against one ear, his feet in cheap rubber slippers.

He blinked, and the image was gone, replaced by the version of himself that had learned, over ten patient years, exactly how much a face can be asked to hold without cracking.

"I did it once already," Vikram said, his hand tightening in his pocket. "When I didn't choose it. When you asked me to."

"Yes."

"This time, I would be choosing it myself."

"Yes," Binay said again. There was something almost like relief in the single word, the sound of a man finally setting down a heavy question he had been carrying longer than his son knew.

Neither of them said the rest of it out loud.

"Choosing it" this time also meant choosing it without a father in the next room to call if things went wrong. These ten remaining weeks or months were the last stretch of road where Vikram would ever again get to make a decision with Binay Ahuja still alive to see it land.

Vikram didn't answer with words.

He reached up and straightened the lapels of his jacket. It was the same way he had once straightened a borrowed apron in front of a bathroom mirror before a ragging that turned out to be nothing worth fearing.

He found that the promise he was making wasn't really to Reddy, who was waiting to be proven wrong in tomorrow's meeting. It wasn't even to the thin man standing beside him, though he owed him more than either of them would ever say plainly.

It was to a nineteen-year-old boy who had once left a Pathology textbook open on a wooden hostel desk, mid-sentence, and never gotten to finish reading it.

I'll finish something for you, he thought, his eyes fixed on the reflection of the empty boardroom. Not that. But something else.

"Tell them yes, Papa," Vikram said, turning to face his father. "South India. All of it."

Binay Ahuja nodded once. It was the nod of a man who had expected this answer from the beginning, but was still glad to hear it spoken out loud.

They stood together at the window for a while longer, saying nothing else. Below them, the city went on, the headlights of the cars moving along the bypass exactly as they had before either of them had decided anything at all.

[End of Part 5]

PART 6

I didn't know any of this when it actually happened.

Vikram never told me the story of that board meeting, or the double exposure on the glass window, or Ira Sen's name. Not once. Not even later when we were old men sitting on the hospital bench and had run out of things to hide from each other.

I pieced the story together the way you piece together most of a friend's life that you weren't present for. I gathered it from a stray line here, a name mentioned once in passing and never again, a nurse's file at the clinic, and an old clerk who still remembered "Ahuja Sahib" fondly enough to talk to me after the funeral.

Some of it, I admit, I am still guessing at. I will say so plainly when I am.

But what I do know for certain, because he told me this part directly, once, was spoken when we were sitting outside the ICU with two cold cups of tea that neither of us drank.

"I never wanted the business, Adarsh," he had said, his voice flat. "Twice, life decided for me. Not once."

I asked him what he meant by twice.

"1996. Then 2007," he replied. "My father's liver, both times. The first time, it let go of him a little, giving him ten more years. The second time, it didn't."

He didn't explain further, and I didn't ask him to. Some men tell you a raw fact and expect you to sit with it, not chase it with questions.

I sat with that fact for years before I truly understood what he meant.

Two times, a decade apart, the exact same door had opened and pulled him out of the life he had actually chosen for himself—a stethoscope, a dissecting table, a hostel room, a friend, me. And both times, it had placed him behind a desk he had never asked to sit at.

Most men would have called that unfair, cursed their luck, and stopped there.

Vikram didn't run either time. He stood his ground, took the pen, and signed.

I know that much for certain, because I watched what came after, even the parts I didn't fully understand until decades later.

That was the board meeting. That was the window.

That, as I would learn only after his death, was also Ira Sen. Her name he mentioned to me exactly once in fifty years, and only in passing, as if checking that the old wound was still there before moving on.

But that was only the beginning. The real test came next.

[End of Part 6]

CHAPTER III: THE BROWN CHAIR

PART 1

The company had no office in this state yet. There was only a corporate name that meant absolutely nothing to the locals, and a leather folder of licenses waiting to be argued over in the municipal offices.

They had put him up wherever the local project team could arrange cheaply. It turned out to be a quiet, stone-walled farmhouse on a hillside outside the main town, surrounded by half-wild orchards and coffee plants, with the thick jungle pressing close against the far fence.

Vikram arrived alone in the back of the car, except for a driver whose name he had already forgotten, and a heavy leather suitcase that was not made for these unpaved dirt roads.

Ramanna kept the place. He was an old caretaker who carried a metal torch that flickered more than it lit, wore a white dhoti pressed into permanent wrinkles, and had a habit of calling every visitor "sir" in a dry tone that made the word sound like a question.

"Board members usually don't come to the site themselves," Ramanna said, unlocking the single guest room. "They send their junior officers."

"I am the junior," Vikram said, setting his bag on the wooden rack.

Ramanna looked at him properly for the first time, his dark eyes studying Vikram's tailored shirt and tired face. He decided something privately, nodded, and said nothing further about it.

The room smelled of the last rain, and the one before that, a damp, earthy scent that clung to the heavy wooden rafters.

Vikram lay on the narrow cot, listening to the sounds that the city of Calcutta never let him hear. Some insect worked continuously at nothing in the corner, a dog somewhere on the hillside decided against barking at the last moment, and the old teak wood of the rafters creaked as it cooled for the night.

Sleep did not come easily anymore. It hadn't come easily since Ira, and since the daily board meetings had started depending on which way a state minister's mood tilted on a given morning.

He got up to get a glass of water near midnight and looked out the window.

It was not close. Past the rows of coffee plants, at the very edge where the plantation gave up and the dark jungle properly began, a small flame moved. It was the kind of flame that only moves when someone is sitting beside it, keeping it alive.

A figure sat by the fire, motionless except for one arm rising and falling in a slow rhythm. Vikram couldn't place the movement from this distance; the figure was either throwing something into the fire or gathering something from the ashes.

He watched the flame for a long time, the glass of water cold in his hand, before returning to his bed.

At breakfast the next morning, Vikram sat on the stone verandah. He ate curd rice with a lime pickle sharp enough to clear his head faster than the chicory-scented coffee did.

Ramanna was scrubbing a copper vessel near the well. Vikram looked at him. "Who lights the fires past the plantation at night, Ramanna?"

The caretaker didn't look up from his work, his hands moving in circular motions. "Aghori Baba."

"Someone from the local village?"

"From nowhere, sir. From the jungle," Ramanna said. "He comes some nights, not others. Nobody invited him here, and nobody has told him to leave, so he stays." He shrugged, a gesture that closed the subject more firmly than any sentence could have.

"What does he do out there?" Vikram asked.

"Whatever Aghoris do." Ramanna finally looked up, wiping his wet hands on his dhoti. "If you want my advice, sir, don't go and ask him. He will tell you. That is the trouble with him. He always tells you."

Vikram laughed. It was the first time he had laughed in longer than he could place exactly.

He didn't take the advice.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

On the second night, Vikram went out to the fire. He told himself it was simply for a short walk to clear his head, the way people tell themselves small lies when they have already decided otherwise.

The Aghori did not look up as Vikram approached the edge of the jungle. He didn't stop the regular motion of his hand.

It was ash, Vikram saw now, as he stepped closer into the circle of firelight. The Aghori lifted a handful from a small heap beside him and let it slide slowly through his fingers, over and over, into a fire that didn't seem to need any other fuel than that dry grey dust.

"Sit down if you are going to sit," the Aghori said, his voice deep and raspy. "Standing there at the edge of the light is worse manners than sitting."

Vikram sat on a smooth stone, keeping a distance that felt safe but probably wasn't.

"You run something," the Aghori said. It was not a question.

"A company," Vikram said, looking at the embers. "My father's company."

"Your father's." The Aghori repeated the phrase the way a teacher repeats a student's mistake back to him, gently, so he can hear the error himself. "And whose is it now?"

Vikram didn't answer that. The fire crackled, a small pocket of sap popping in the dry wood.

The Aghori let another handful of grey ash slip between his fingers, falling back into the flames. "Everything you are building," he said, pointing a finger at the suitcase Vikram had left in his room, "this is what it will become. But that doesn't mean you shouldn't build it."

Vikram came back to the edge of the jungle on the third night. This time, he didn't need to be told to sit; he walked directly to the stone and sat down.

"What is that?" Vikram asked, nodding toward the small pile of grey dust.

"A body," the Aghori said, as if he were discussing the weather. "Somebody's body, once. It doesn't really matter whose."

Vikram watched the ash fall.

"You people in the cities are frightened of this," the Aghori said, looking at the flames. "But I sit in it. I sleep in it on some nights when the wind is cold. It stops being frightening once you understand it isn't waiting for you specially. It is just where everyone ends up."

"That is a very bleak way to live," Vikram said.

"Is it?" The Aghori looked at him for the first time properly, his eyes catching the yellow firelight in a way that made Vikram look away first. "Or is it the only honest way to live? Maybe everything else you do is just very good decoration around the same simple fact."

Vikram had no answer for that either, and the Aghori didn't seem to expect one.

By the fourth day, the Aghori had started appearing at the farmhouse itself during the daylight hours. He sat on the low stone wall outside Vikram's guest room as if he had always been permitted there.

Perhaps, in Ramanna's silent accounting of the world, he had. The caretaker brought him a glass of hot tea without being asked, the way you would bring tea to an old uncle who visits too rarely to be told to stop.

"Empty," the Aghori said one afternoon, watching Vikram read through a thick stack of licensing agreements on the verandah.

"What is?" Vikram asked, looking up.

"All of it. This," he gestured with his ash-stained hand toward the papers, the farmhouse, the coffee hills, and the sky. "It will pass. You will pass. The company will pass. Even this tea in my glass will be finished in a minute, and no one will remember it was ever hot."

"Then why bother with any of it?" Vikram asked, leaning back against the stone pillar. "Why build the factories?"

"I didn't say don't bother," the Aghori said, drinking his tea slowly. "I said don't be surprised when it goes. That is a different thing entirely. A man who expects the tea to go cold still drinks it while it is hot. Only a fool sits waiting for it to stay warm forever, and calls that patience."

Vikram looked down at the licensing papers. Oddly, he found himself finishing his reading faster that afternoon, and minding the dry details less.

He didn't tell Reddy, when they spoke on the phone that evening about the land acquisition, why his voice sounded calmer than it had in months. He wasn't sure he could have explained it correctly even if he had tried.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

Ramanna asked him on the fifth morning, formally, standing straighter on the stone verandah than Vikram had yet seen him stand.

"Sir," the caretaker said, his hands folded in front of his chest. "My daughter Lakshmi's marriage is the day after tomorrow. You are staying under my roof, and it would be my honor if you attend the ceremony."

"I don't want to intrude on your family's space," Vikram said, looking at the invitation.

"Intrude?" Ramanna looked genuinely wounded by the word, his shoulders dropping slightly. "You are staying in my house, sir. If you don't come, the whole village will ask what is wrong with my hospitality and why the big company boss is hiding."

Vikram went.

The wedding took over the entire dirt lane outside Ramanna's small house.

A pandal of bamboo poles and colored cloth had been thrown up in two days, with green banana stems tied to every entrance pillar, and fresh mango leaves strung across the gate in lines that dipped and rose in the warm breeze.

Somebody put a heavy paper plate into Vikram's hands before he had even finished taking off his leather shoes near the verandah steps.

"Eat, eat," said a middle-aged woman he hadn't been introduced to. She ladled a second helping of hot, steaming sambar onto his banana leaf before he could protest that he hadn't finished the first portion. "You have come from so far away, from the city. You must eat properly in this house."

He tried explaining that he was only staying at the plantation for two more days, but she didn't appear to hear that part of his sentence over the noise of the crowd.

By the second course of the meal, Vikram had been fed by at least four different aunts, each one convinced the previous three had not given him enough food.

An uncle with a red, paan-stained smile sat beside him and remarked that he looked "too thin for a business tycoon, no offense intended, sir." Vikram found, to his own surprise, that he didn't take the comment as an insult.

The wedding ceremony itself happened in pieces that Vikram could only half follow.

He watched the priest's Sanskrit chants run fast and rhythmic over the sacrificial fire, the smoke rising toward the cloth roof. He saw the bride, Lakshmi, wearing heavy temple gold jewelry that looked far too heavy for her thin wrists, and her new husband's hands shaking slightly as he tied the yellow thread of the mangalsutra.

There was a sudden, loud roar of conch shells and women's ululation that made Vikram's ears ring pleasantly for a full minute after the knot was tied.

Nobody in the crowd asked him for anything. Nobody wanted a corporate license signed, a new labor policy explained, or a board of directors satisfied.

They simply wanted him to eat more rice and curry, which he found himself doing without any hesitation.

On the second evening of the festivities, Vikram sat on Ramanna's verandah with his mobile phone pressed against his ear. He could hear the brass wedding band still playing some movie tunes somewhere down the lane behind him.

"Sir, the minister's office has confirmed the meeting for Thursday morning," his assistant's voice said from the speaker. "Reddy sir has traveled from Hyderabad and will meet you at the gate directly."

"Good," Vikram said.

"Also, sir... are you well? Your voice sounds different on the phone."

Vikram considered several ways of answering that statement that were completely true. "I have been eating a lot of sambar," he said finally.

His assistant, after a brief pause of confusion, decided not to ask any further questions. Vikram appreciated that silence more than she probably knew.

Ramanna found him on the steps after the call ended. He was carrying two glasses of hot, over-sweet tea, and he settled onto the concrete step beside Vikram without waiting to be invited.

"Good wedding?" Vikram asked, taking the hot glass.

"Good wedding," Ramanna agreed, blowing on his tea. He added the only compliment he seemed to consider worth giving: "You ate properly, at least. My wife was worried that a big company man from Calcutta wouldn't touch our village food."

"It was better than anything the board canteens serve," Vikram said, taking a sip of the sweet tea.

Ramanna laughed—a short, surprised bark of a laugh, as if he hadn't expected the city boss to tell the truth.

They sat together on the step for a long time, saying nothing else. Behind them, the brass band worked through the same four wedding songs for the third time that night, and neither man minded the noise in the least.

[End of Part 3]

PART 4

Reddy was waiting outside the Secretariat gate when Vikram's car pulled up. He was standing in the thin shade of a neem tree, a newspaper folded into thirds held loosely in one hand, the way you hold something when you have stopped expecting the car to arrive on time.

"You look well-rested," Reddy said by way of greeting. He adjusted his glasses, sounding almost suspicious of the fact.

"Ramanna's wedding," Vikram said, adjusting his collar. "His daughter's."

"Whose wedding?"

"It is a long story," Vikram said, opening the door of the administrative building.

Reddy studied him for a moment, decided not to pursue the matter, and turned toward the dark corridor of the entrance. "Don't expect the same kind of hospitality in here as you got in the village."

The Minister's outer office ran on its own private, glacial clock.

Twenty minutes became forty, and forty slowly stretched into an hour. A peon brought two rounds of sweet tea in small glasses that nobody had asked for, while a queue of other petitioners came and went ahead of them with the easy confidence of people who had learned exactly which palms needed greasing and which doors required patience.

The peon — his name, Vikram read from the small laminated badge on his shirt, was Murthy — had been the one whose chai break had temporarily halted the office seal. He returned from it with a slightly defensive air, setting down the tea glasses and mentioning, to nobody in particular, that the canteen queue had been unusually long today because they were serving kesari bath, which is why it took so long, and by the way was there anything else required at this moment.

Nobody answered him.

He found something to do at the far end of the corridor and was gone again within four minutes.

"This is normal," Reddy said, not looking up from the legal files resting on his lap. "Don't take the delay personally."

"I'm not," Vikram said.

"You are checking your watch every four minutes," Reddy pointed out, his voice dry.

Vikram stopped checking his watch and rested his hands on the armrests of the vinyl chair.

Minister Satyanarayana, when they were finally shown in, turned out to be a small, unhurried man sitting behind a very large teak desk. He gestured for them to sit without getting up himself, and came to the point much faster than the long wait outside had suggested he would.

"Liquor," the Minister said, rolling the word on his tongue as if tasting it and not much liking it. "Do you know what that word does to my file in this state during an election year?"

"I understand it is politically sensitive, sir," Vikram said.

"Sensitive?" The Minister smiled, a dry expression that had no warmth in it. "My predecessor lost his assembly seat over a minor liquor policy change. Not because people stopped drinking. But because the opposition newspapers made him look like the man who let the poor family go hungry so he could line his pockets. It doesn't matter if it is true. It only has to be sayable."

Reddy leaned forward, his hands resting on the edge of the desk. "Sir, with respect, the industry exists whether or not our company enters the market. We are asking for a simple land allocation for a compliant, licensed unit. Nothing about the moral question changes because of who holds the license."

"Everything about the moral question changes based on whose name is printed on the license, Reddy garu," the Minister said, his voice dropping. "You know this game as well as I do. Your father's company is a big name. A big target, if the opposition wants to make an example of us."

"So the land is not available," Vikram said.

"I didn't say that," the Minister said, leaning back in his tall leather chair. "I said it is not available easily. There is a difference, and that difference costs time, not just money."

Outside, back in the car as it pulled into the heavy traffic of the main road, Reddy didn't bother softening the truth.

"This is exactly what I meant in the boardroom," Reddy said, looking out the side window. "This isn't home ground, Vikram. Here, every 'no' has to be understood as a 'maybe,' and every 'maybe' has to be earned twice over, because nobody down here owes your father's name anything yet."

"I heard you the first time. In the boardroom," Vikram said.

"Hearing and understanding are not the same thing," Reddy said, his tone firm but not unkind. "I'll be honest with you. I still don't know if this land allocation will come through in a month or in three years. It could go either way. It could not go at all."

Vikram looked out the window at the heavy iron gates of the Secretariat shrinking behind them in the dust.

"Then we wait," Vikram said quietly. "And we don't waste the waiting."

Reddy glanced at him sideways, as if that sentence hadn't sounded quite like the Vikram he had expected to manage on this trip. He said nothing about it, filing the observation away the way careful men file things they intend to bring up again when the pressure rises.

[End of Part 4]

PART 5

He left on the sixth morning. The car was already loaded and idling in the driveway, with Ramanna hovering near the boot, insisting on carrying a small suitcase that Vikram was perfectly capable of lifting himself.

The Aghori was waiting by the rows of coffee plants at the edge of the yard, as if he had known the exact morning of Vikram's departure without being told.

"Going," the Aghori said. It was not a question.

"For now," Vikram said, stopping near the low wall. "The land isn't settled yet. I will be traveling back and forth for months, maybe even longer."

"Land is never really settled," the Aghori said, sitting on the stones. "It is only borrowed for a little while. Tell me something before you go. Why this? Liquor. Why not medicine, or schools, or something that a father could be simply proud of at dinner parties?"

Vikram considered lying. He thought of the polished, corporate answers he usually gave to the board members and the politicians, but he found he didn't want to use those words here.

"It wasn't mine to choose," Vikram said, looking at the distant hills. "It was my father's business. I never wanted it—not the company, not this industry. Twice, life put me in it anyway. I am not chasing the money; I stopped believing money was the point a long time ago. I just want to finish what he started, properly, because he cannot do it anymore, and because some part of me still wants to prove I can."

"And the liquor part," the Aghori asked, his dark eyes steady. "Does that trouble you?"

"Yes," Vikram said, not softening the truth. "I know what it does to some families. I have read the same social reports that the opposition will use against our factory. I am not proud of the product. But I am proud, perhaps, of doing it honestly where I can—keeping the license clean, the taxes paid, and the workers looked after. It is not nothing. But it is also not everything."

The Aghori looked at him for a long moment. The fire-catch in his eyes from the night before was replaced now, in the clear daylight, by something much quieter.

Then he smiled, a slow, gentle expression. He didn't explain the smile, and Vikram, who had learned by now not to ask, didn't request any explanation.

"Here," the Aghori said instead.

He produced from somewhere in his ash-grey wrap a small piece of folded paper, handing it over without any ceremony.

"Sit like this in the morning," the Aghori said. "Ten minutes, no more. And this word, repeat it when your mind runs too fast for you to catch it. It is not for the liquor board, and not for your father. It is for you, when you are alone and nobody is watching, and you still don't know who you are supposed to be that day."

Vikram unfolded the paper later, in the back of the car as they drove down the winding hill road.

He found a simple seated posture sketched in a shaky, dark hand. Beneath the drawing, a single word was written twice, the second time heavily underlined.

He didn't ask what the word meant. Some part of him suspected that the very act of not-asking was the real point of the gift.

Ramanna knocked on the car window as the vehicle began to move, breathless from jogging alongside it for the last few steps down the gravel path.

"Sir!" the caretaker called out, waving his hand. "Come again for the next wedding, whenever there is one in our family!"

Vikram laughed, a real, clear laugh, and promised that he would. He found—a little to his own surprise—that he meant it.

[End of Part 5]

PART 6

The telephone call came eleven days later. Vikram was back at the head office in Calcutta, in the middle of a tedious meeting about new tea packaging labels.

The directors were arguing over the size of the company logo on the cardboard boxes. Vikram stepped out into the quiet corridor to take the call on his mobile.

"You won't believe this," Reddy's voice said from the receiver. For once in his life, the senior director sounded like he meant the phrase literally, rather than using it as a figure of speech.

"What happened, Reddy?"

"The local MLA called Minister Satyanarayana's office yesterday afternoon," Reddy said. "He told them to process our land allocation file immediately. No conditions, no delays, no extra meetings."

"Why?" Vikram asked, looking through the corridor glass.

"Nobody knows why. That is the part I don't believe," Reddy exhaled audibly down the line. "The man has been sitting on this file for two years, blocking it for reasons nobody could ever get straight. And now, suddenly, it's done."

Vikram listened to the hum of the phone line.

"Doesn't matter," Reddy continued. "Take the win, Vikram. And it gets even better. They have allotted double the acreage we originally asked for. Somebody upstairs must have decided to make it worth our while, or make up for lost time, or God knows what. I stopped trying to explain government logic years ago."

Vikram looked out through the glass wall of the office corridor. Below, the ordinary Tuesday traffic of Calcutta crawled along the main street, people going about their ordinary errands with no idea that a two-year corporate deadlock somewhere else had just, inexplicably, come undone.

"Vikram? You there?" Reddy asked. "This is very good news, in case that wasn't clear."

"I heard you, Reddy. It is good news."

"You don't sound like it is good news."

"I am glad," Vikram said. He checked himself honestly, and found that he was—it was a clean, quiet gladness, without the fist-clenched triumph he might once have felt at the same news a year ago. "I just don't feel like I need to do anything loud about being glad. Does that make sense?"

"No," Reddy said. "But congratulations anyway. I will meet you at the site next week."

That evening, alone in the hotel room he still hadn't gotten used to, Vikram found the folded paper again. It was in the inside pocket of his jacket, where he had been carrying it without quite noticing he had.

He sat on the floor, crossing his legs the way the shaky sketch showed. He closed his eyes and breathed, doing it for the ten minutes the paper said, no more.

He did not feel suddenly transformed. He didn't feel anything cinematic or magical.

He felt, mostly, like a man who had stopped needing the outcome to arrive on time in order to keep doing his work anyway. He suspected, without being able to say exactly why, that this was the entire point of the exercise, and probably the entire point of the word he had been given.

Somewhere past the hotel window, past the city traffic, past several states, a small fire was probably still burning at the edge of a coffee plantation. It was tended by a man who would likely never know what his ash and his silence had helped set in motion.

Vikram didn't call the plantation to tell anyone. Some things, he was beginning to understand, were not owed an explanation. Not even a grateful one.

He went back to his desk and his files that night, feeling lighter than he had in years. The land allocation, when it finally arrived on official government stamp paper three weeks later, felt less like a hard-fought victory than like a simple fact he had already made peace with in advance.

[End of Part 6]

PART 7

The chair came with the office. The office itself was really just two rooms above a spare-parts godown, which the company had converted in a hurry because nothing better was available yet in this industrial city.

The chair was made of brown leatherette, cracked deeply along both armrests where the stuffing was beginning to show. One wheel was permanently stuck, which made the whole chair list two degrees to the left if you weren't careful when standing up.

Vikram's manager here, a sharp young man named Suresh, had tried twice to get it replaced during his first month.

"Sir, we can easily order a proper executive leather chair from Hyderabad," Suresh said. "The company budget allows for it, and it will look much more professional for meetings."

"This one works," Vikram said, adjusting a folder on his desk.

"It is falling apart, sir."

"It hasn't fallen apart yet," Vikram replied.

Suresh gave up after the second attempt. He filed his boss under the general category of eccentric, wealthy men he didn't need to understand in order to work for.

Vikram sat in the listing chair the night the first major factory workers' wage dispute came to his desk.

Eleven men had gone three months without pay because a regional distributor had defaulted on his payments, and the company's own cash was temporarily tied up in a land deal that still hadn't cleared.

Vikram could have waited. Legally, under the terms of the contract, he had every ground to wait until the distributor was taken to court.

But he sat in the cracked chair until past midnight, going through the ledger numbers twice. By morning, he had found a way to release a partial emergency payment from a different reserve account, telling Suresh to arrange the bank drafts before the workers even arrived at the office to ask.

"That is not how the corporate process usually works, sir," Suresh said, holding the draft authorization.

"I know."

"The head office in Calcutta will ask questions about this transfer."

"Let them ask," Vikram said, looking at his desk.

He sat in the chair again three weeks later, the night a second factory's water-supply request needed approval. It was a project that would cost the company far more than the state government would ever reimburse.

He approved it anyway. He knew the alternative was six hundred local families carrying water two kilometers by hand indefinitely while the paperwork moved slowly through government channels designed to take years.

"Why not just replace the thing?" Reddy asked one afternoon, visiting the site and eyeing the cracked leatherette with open disapproval. "It looks like something waiting to collapse under you."

"Because it doesn't let me forget," Vikram said.

"Forget what?"

Vikram didn't answer immediately. He ran one thumb along the cracked edge of the left armrest, the way another man might touch an old scar to check if it was still there.

"Every time I sit in something comfortable, Reddy, I start making comfortable decisions," Vikram said, looking up. "This chair reminds me every few minutes that it could give way. It keeps me honest about what is actually

at stake when I sign these papers."

Reddy looked at him for a long moment, the way a man looks at someone he is revising an old, hard opinion about. He didn't say anything about the chair then.

He would, eventually—but that conversation belonged to a different night, a different pot of tea, still some weeks away. For now, the brown chair held, listing its two degrees to the left, and Vikram kept signing what needed signing, one cracked-leather night at a time.

[End of Part 7]

PART 8

Reddy came to the house himself this time. He wasn't summoned by any boardroom schedule, and he carried a blue folder that he kept patting with his hand as if it might run away from him.

Binay received him in the small sitting room off his bedroom, the one with the single good leather chair reserved for visitors. The old man was thinner now than even the board meeting had shown, but he was alert and sharp-eyed, waving off the private nurse who hovered near the doorway.

"Binay saab," Reddy said, sitting down. He opened the folder on his knees, then seemed to forget the numbers entirely and just spoke. "Seven hundred crore. That is what the liquor division was doing when your son took over the South expansion. This year, it has crossed fourteen hundred crore."

Binay's eyebrows lifted slightly. That was the whole of his reaction, but it seemed to satisfy Reddy more than a long speech would have.

Pradhan-babu, who had been standing near the doorway to refill the water glass, set the jug down on the console table and said nothing. He had worked for Binay Ahuja for thirty-one years and had never heard a crore figure that size said aloud in this room. He stood very still for a moment, then quietly refilled the glass and went back to his desk.

"South alone has brought six hundred crore," Reddy continued, pointing at the chart. "Manufactured there, and now exported worldwide. Nobody on the board thought a first-time entrant would touch international distribution this fast. We are already scouting land for two more plants. If this holds, the company touches ten thousand crore within five years."

"You were the one who called him a kid in front of the others," Binay said, not unkindly, watching Reddy's face carefully.

"I was," Reddy said, not looking away from his gaze. "And I will say it again if I am ever wrong about someone else. But I was wrong about this one."

Vikram stood near the window through all of this, saying very little. It was the way he had learned to stand in most rooms that discussed him rather than spoke to him.

When Reddy rose to leave, he crossed the room and rested his hand briefly on Vikram's shoulder. It wasn't a formal handshake or a congratulatory speech; it was just a hand, there for a second and gone, the kind of gesture older men give when they have run out of better ways to say something.

Vikram felt something loosen in his chest that he hadn't realized was tight.

He stood at the window for a long time after Reddy's car had pulled away, watching the iron gate close slowly behind the tail-lights. He found that the warmth of the moment faded much faster than he expected it to.

Fourteen hundred crore. Ten thousand crore in five years.

These were numbers that would have meant everything to him once, when he was in a hostel room, imagining a life entirely different from this one.

But he didn't feel any great triumph. He felt something closer to a duty discharged than a dream fulfilled. Like finishing a borrowed book he had never quite wanted to read, but had carried too long to return unfinished.

Liquor had been his father's calling, not his. He had carried it forward because someone had to, because the alternative was letting Binay's life's work collapse under a medical diagnosis that nobody could argue with anymore.

Somewhere underneath the fourteen hundred crore, a much smaller, much older thought kept surfacing, uninvited, like a seed in the wind: **what would I have built, if I had been building for myself instead of for him?**

He did not know the answer to that question yet. He wasn't even sure, standing at that window in the dark, that he was supposed to be looking for one.

[End of Part 8]

PART 9

The phone call came the next morning, before Vikram had finished his first cup of tea at the desk.

"Bhaiya," Meena's voice said. She was Rohan's wife, and her voice sounded tight and fast, in the way voices get when they have been holding themselves together only for the length of a phone call. "Please... don't panic. But Rohan has been arrested by the local police."

"Arrested?" Vikram sat up, setting his cup down. "For what?"

"They are saying illegal transactions, tender bypass, false documents—all false, bhaiya, I swear on our daughter, all of it is false," she sobbed. "Rohan wouldn't sign off on the Nandyal plant construction certificate. The contractor's concrete mixing ratio was weak, and Rohan caught it himself. He refused to certify it. Yesterday, the contractor's men came to the site office to threaten him, and today the police came to our house with a warrant."

Vikram sat very still, the receiver pressed against his ear, watching the tea cool in front of him.

"He took that Nandyal site engineer job on his own," Meena said, her voice quieter now, almost apologetic, as if this fact embarrassed her on his behalf. "He wouldn't let me tell you he had applied for it. He wanted to clear the selection without anyone knowing whose brother he was."

"I know," Vikram said.

"Please don't tell Papa, bhaiya," she whispered. "His heart condition—please, not right now."

"I won't tell him. I am coming there immediately."

The local police station smelled of damp old paper, dust, and stale tea. A rusted ceiling fan turned too slowly to make any difference in the heat.

Rohan was sitting on a wooden bench outside the lock-up corridor, his hands resting on his knees. He had a swollen, cut lip that he was trying to hide from the room, but he wasn't doing a very good job of it.

He looked up when Vikram walked through the main door, and something in his eyes shifted—first confusion, then a brief flash of pride, before settling on a flat silence.

"You didn't need to come here," Rohan said.

"Meena called me. Not you," Vikram said, standing in front of him.

"I told her not to call Calcutta."

"I know that too."

The sub-inspector, who had been slow and unhelpful with Meena's earlier phone calls, changed completely within four minutes of Vikram's lawyer arriving. The lawyer carried the right papers, and made the right phone calls to the right names in the district headquarters.

Suddenly, the officer became a considerably more helpful version of himself. He offered hot tea, pulled out chairs, and delivered a long apology in the specific, polite tone reserved for men who fear they have made an expensive mistake with a powerful family.

Rohan watched all of this from his wooden bench, silent. The swelling around his lip was the only part of his face that showed any reaction.

He had been on that same bench for four hours before Vikram arrived. Back then, before any lawyer came, before any big corporate name attached itself to his case, he was just a young site engineer who wouldn't sign a false document. He had been treated exactly like every other ordinary man who refused to sign what the local police were told to make him sign.

Nobody had offered him a glass of tea then.

In the car afterward, Rohan stared out the side window without speaking for most of the drive back to the house.

"Thank you," he said finally. The words arrived stiff and heavy, like something handed over reluctantly because it was owed, rather than because he truly felt it.

"You would have done the same for me, Rohan," Vikram said.

"Would I?" Rohan said, his voice flat. He didn't turn to look at his brother. "I don't have a corporate lawyer on retainer who can make sub-inspectors pull out chairs and apologize, Vikram."

"That is not what I meant."

"I know what you meant," Rohan said, looking out at the passing trees. "But it doesn't change what I saw in that room."

Rohan didn't say what he had seen, not directly, and Vikram didn't push him to explain.

But something had shifted in the younger brother's face somewhere between the police bench and the car. Vikram didn't have a word for it yet, and Rohan spent the rest of the drive making sure he never got the chance to ask.

The house was a two-storey structure with a stone compound wall and a metal gate that Rohan had chosen and paid for himself. He had bought the house before the wedding, and the fact of that ownership was something he carried with him in the way a man carries a document he has not yet found the occasion to show.

Meena came to the door when they heard the car. She had a daughter on her hip, the child no more than three, with Rohan's narrow forehead and Meena's large, dark eyes. She looked at her husband's swollen lip first, then at Vikram, and then back at Rohan.

She said nothing. In four years of marriage, she had learned to read the particular quality of Rohan's silence the way other women read their children's faces.

"Go inside and change your clothes," Rohan said to her, not looking at her, already moving toward the small room he used as a study. "The Nandyal survey drawings are on the desk. I need to go through them tonight."

Meena handed the child to the neighbor who had been watching her, and went inside.

Vikram set his bag down near the door. Through the open study door, he could see the drawings spread across the desk—rolled sheets of blueprint paper, the penciled markings in Rohan's careful, precise hand.

When Meena came back, she was wearing a dark green silk saree with a heavy gold border. She had also put her bangles on, the full set. Her hair was pressed back neatly. She stood near the doorway of the study with her hands clasped in front of her, waiting.

Rohan was sitting at the desk with a scale, checking measurements against a printed specification sheet. He didn't look up.

She stood there.

He made a note in the margin, used the eraser, and made it again. His jaw was tight under the swelling. The room was quiet except for the scratch of his pencil and the slow tick of the wall clock.

She was still standing.

Vikram looked at her. He looked at the way she had clasped her hands, the careful stillness of it, the way you hold yourself very still so that you don't make a sound in a room where sound has become a problem.

He looked away. He had seen enough to understand something he had not been meant to understand, and not enough to know what to do with it.

"I'll be at the guest house," Vikram said, from near the door.

Rohan didn't look up from the blueprint. "Have dinner before you go."

"I ate on the road."

He picked up his bag and left. The metal gate clicked shut behind him.

As he walked to the road, he looked back once at the lit window of the study. He could see the outline of Meena's shadow, still and straight near the doorframe, and Rohan's bent head above the blueprints.

The child was crying somewhere at the back of the house, softly, the way children cry when they have given up on being heard immediately.

[End of Part 9]

PART 10

The new manufacturing plant at Nandyal sat on twelve acres of former cotton land. The soil was still bright red, showing between the grey concrete foundations of the bottling unit like dried blood on concrete.

A tall chain-link fence ran all the way around the property. The top of the fence carried three tight strands of galvanized barbed wire that caught the glare of the morning sun.

Vikram sat in his brown leatherette chair. It was no longer located in the two rooms above the spare-parts godown.

Suresh had moved it to the new administrative wing, a room that smelled of fresh paint, synthetic floor glue, and the air conditioning that hummed from a white box on the wall.

Suresh had tried to leave the chair behind. "It looks bad, sir," he had said, pointing at the cracked armrests. "The visitors from the state capital—they sit on the new leather in the lobby, then they come in here and see this."

"The visitors don't pay the loaders' wages," Vikram said.

"Still, sir," Suresh protested.

"Leave it," Vikram said.

So the chair had stayed. The stuck wheel that listed the chair two degrees to the left had already made a dark, curved streak on the new grey linoleum floor.

From his wide window, Vikram could see the entire loading bay. Twelve multi-axle trucks were lined up in the red dust, their engines idling, the grey exhaust smoke rising straight up in the windless heat.

The loaders were mostly local boys from the villages near the hills. They wore faded blue shirts with the company logo printed on the pocket—a simple black malt grain.

A boy of about eighteen was sitting on a wooden crate near the rear tyre of the third truck. He was eating curd rice from a steel tiffin box.

His hands were white with the dust of the cement packing. He used his fingers to scoop the rice quickly, looking at the security gate every few seconds as if he expected a guard to tell him to move.

Vikram watched him from the window.

He remembered table seven in the dissection hall. He remembered the sharp smell of formaldehyde.

Back then, he was a student who had wanted to know the names of the muscles in the human arm so he could heal them.

Now, he knew the names of the local load-unions. He knew how many bags of barley a truck could carry before the highway police demanded a bribe at the border.

The boy near the truck finished his rice, closed the steel tiffin box, and wiped his fingers on the side of the wooden crate. He stood up, adjusted his blue shirt, and went back to the loading ramp.

The signature of Ahuja Sahib on the clearance ledger had given that boy a tiffin box and a faded blue shirt. It was a good thing.

But as Vikram watched the truck move slowly toward the gate, the dust rising to cover the red cotton fields, he felt only the weight of it.

The fourteen hundred crore was a number on a page. The twelve acres was a map in the land register.

But the text in the ledger didn't say how many more boys would have to spend their afternoons in the red Nandyal dust to make the numbers match.

[End of Part 10]

PART 11

*The telegram from Odisha was delivered to the Nandyal administrative office on a quiet Tuesday afternoon. It contained only four words: **Binay serious. Come home.***

Suresh had brought it into the room, his leather boots making a hurried, squeaking sound on the grey linoleum floor.

Vikram didn't read the paper twice. He folded it slowly and stood up from his brown leatherette chair.

"Pack the project files, Suresh," he said, looking at the desk. "I am leaving."

"And the chair, sir?" Suresh asked, looking at the listing seat. "Should we send it by truck to the railway station so you have it in Calcutta?"

Vikram looked at the cracked armrest where the black tape had started peeling away to show the grey foam inside.

"No," Vikram said. "Leave it here. Let someone else sit in it."

He took his small leather bag—the same suitcase he had brought with him five years ago—and walked out to the waiting ambassador car.

The family house in Odisha was silent.

Binay was in the upstairs bedroom, the one that looked out over the kitchen garden. He was propped up on two flat pillows, his breathing shallow and rapid, with the yellow jaundice showing deep in the whites of his half-closed eyes.

Rohan was sitting on the wooden stool near the window. His shoes were clean today, but he kept his hands in his pockets, his shoulders hunched as he watched Vikram enter the room.

Rohan did not stand up to greet him. "You took your time," he said, his voice flat.

"The train was delayed at Khurda junction," Vikram said, walking to the bed.

He sat on the wooden edge of the mattress. Binay's hand on the sheet was dry and cold; the skin felt like loose parchment, the veins rising blue and stiff against the bone.

The old man opened his eyes slowly, looking at Vikram first, and then at Rohan near the window. "The Nandyal plant..." Binay whispered, his voice barely a rasp.

"It is running, Papa," Vikram said, holding his fingers. "The bottling unit is complete. The first shipments have gone out."

Binay nodded once, his eyelids closing again under the weight of the illness. "Rohan," he said, his voice dry.

Rohan stood up from his stool, but he did not come to the bedside. He stayed near the dark wooden wardrobe. "Yes, Papa."

"The company... it is yours now. Both of you," the old man said.

Rohan looked down at the floorboards. "Vikram runs the board, Papa. I am just a site engineer."

Binay did not answer. He had already gone back to that quiet, unmoving state where the words of his sons could no longer reach him.

Vikram stood up and walked to the window.

Down in the kitchen garden, Ramu, the old gardener, was collecting dry neem leaves in a bamboo basket, the leaves crackling softly as he swept.

Rohan looked out at the garden beside him, his voice low and tight. "You should have stayed at the head office. Reddy says you did all the work in the South. He says the board only wants your signature on the expansions."

"The signature is just ink on paper, Rohan," Vikram said.

"It is not," Rohan said, turning his back to the window. "It is what decides whose name goes on the gate."

He walked out of the room. His footsteps were loud on the wooden stairs, fading away until only the slow, heavy breathing of their father remained in the quiet room.

Vikram sat back on the edge of the bed and held the old man's cold hand.

The room smelled of barley water, old linen, and the rubbing alcohol the nurse used for the thermometer. Outside, the sun was setting behind the kitchen garden, casting the shadows of the neem trees long and dark over the compost pit.

He knew this was the last week. He knew the white coat of the doctor was gone forever, and the company was all that remained of his father's expectations.

But as he held his father's cold hand in the dark room, the fourteen hundred crore felt like nothing but a number written on a wall that was about to fall down.

[End of Chapter III]

CHAPTER IV: THE RED TEA

PART 1

The oxygen cylinder beside the bed had a small brass regulator that leaked. If you stood near the head of the bed, in the quiet spaces between the household noises, you could hear it clearly—a tiny, dry hiss like steam escaping a pipe three rooms away.

Vikram had tried to tighten it twice with a spanner he had borrowed from the driver. Both times, the sound had stopped for ten minutes, then returned, slightly thinner but completely unchanged.

Binay Ahuja didn't seem to mind the sound. Or perhaps he had simply stopped separating the mechanical noise of the room from the sound of his own shallow breathing.

His skin had gone the grey-yellow color of an old newspaper left out in the rain.

"Rohan didn't come today," Binay said, his eyes remaining closed. His voice was barely louder than the regulator's hiss.

"He had site inspections at the Nandyal plant, Papa," Vikram said.

"A construction site doesn't go anywhere, Vikram."

"There was a concrete mixing ratio issue. He wanted to check the quality himself."

Binay closed his eyes tighter. The saline line taped to his forearm was empty, and a single bubble of air was trapped near the plastic lock, refusing to move up or down the tube.

"He thinks I don't know," Binay whispered, his lips dry.

"Know what, Papa?"

"That he took that engineering job because he didn't want to sit in your shadow here in Calcutta."

Vikram didn't answer. He sat on the folding metal chair near the wardrobe, his hands clasped between his knees.

The bedroom smelled of boiled barley water, old dust, and the rubbing spirit the nurse used to clean the thermometer.

"Let him," Binay said, after a long silence. "It is better to build a small wall yourself than to live in a palace someone else gave you."

The phone call came at four in the morning. It was the family doctor, Dr. Joshi, calling from the house.

*He didn't use the words he usually used during his weekly checks. There was no talk of **portal pressure** or **we'll monitor the vitals**.*

He simply said: "Vikram. Come."

The family house in Odisha had two gates.

*The main gate was wide, iron-grilled, with two granite pillars that had **Ahuja Villa** engraved in white marble plates. The side gate was small, painted green, leading directly through a gap in the boundary wall to the kitchen garden.*

Vikram used the side gate when the car pulled up.

The kitchen was already open, the lights bright. The old family cook, Ramu, was sitting on a low wooden stool, cleaning cardamom pods in a wide brass plate.

He didn't look up when Vikram entered, his fingers moving slowly. "Joshi saab is inside," Ramu said, sorting the black seeds from the green husks. "He asked for black coffee."

"Is Rohan here?"

"He arrived at three. He is in the study room."

Vikram walked down the long corridor. The house felt larger than it had yesterday, the high ceilings echoing the silence.

The lights were all turned on, but they seemed to illuminate only the corners of the rooms, leaving the heavy teak furniture in a grey, unmoving shade.

Dr. Joshi was standing near the study door, his stethoscope already packed, his black leather bag zipped and placed on the corner table. He looked at Vikram and nodded once.

"Heart stopped at three-forty," the doctor said, his voice quiet. "No pain. He simply ceased."

Vikram stood there, his eyes fixed on the doctor's bag. It was a black leather bag with a worn handle, the leather peeling near the brass lock to show the grey fabric underneath.

"Rohan is inside," Joshi said, touching Vikram's arm briefly as he walked toward the door. "Go talk to him."

The study room was cold. Binay's large teak wood desk was completely empty, except for a brass paperweight shaped like a lion.

Rohan was sitting in the guest chair. His leather shoes were covered in red Nandyal dust, a dry crust of it clinging to the welt of his left heel.

He didn't look up when Vikram entered the room. "You should have called me earlier," Rohan said, his voice flat.

"I called at midnight, Rohan. Your phone was switched off."

"The site office has no network after ten. You know that."

"I sent the driver to fetch you."

"The driver took three hours to reach the site," Rohan said. His voice was tight and thin, like a wire drawn too straight. "He arrived after the doctor had already signed the death certificate."

He stood up and walked to the window, looking out at the dark kitchen garden where Ramu was now throwing kitchen waste into the compost pit.

"Rohan," Vikram said.

"Don't," Rohan said, his back still turned. "Don't use that tone. The 'elder brother' tone."

He turned back to face the room. His lip was still slightly dark near the corner where the contractor's men had hit him three months ago.

"Everyone at the construction site knew before I did," Rohan said, his eyes narrowing. "The contractor's supervisor came to my cabin at two. He said, 'Ahuja Sahib is serious, you should leave.' He said it like he was giving me a concession."

"He was trying to help, Rohan."

"He was showing me that even my father's death is company business," Rohan said. He walked to the desk, his finger tracing the brass lion's mane.

"Seven hundred crore. Fourteen hundred crore. Ten thousand crore. That's what you and Reddy talk about in the office. That's what is printed in the financial papers."

He looked at Vikram properly now. "Papa died in this house. The house belongs to the company. The car Dr. Joshi came in belongs to the company. Even the shroud we will buy today will be billed to the office account."

"Rohan—"

"I don't want it," Rohan said. He spoke louder now, his voice echoing off the high ceiling of the study. "I don't want your charity. I don't want to be the younger brother who was given a site-engineer job to keep him quiet."

"You chose that job yourself."

"Because it was the only one where nobody asked who my brother was!"

A heavy silence followed. The old ceiling fan in the study gave a low, metallic groan as it turned.

Rohan sat back down in the guest chair. "He wanted a doctor," Rohan whispered, looking at the empty desk. "He wanted you to wear the white coat. He told me that when I was twelve. 'Vicky will be the doctor.' He said it like I was just the spare."

"He didn't mean that, Rohan."

"He did," Rohan said. "And then you left the college. You took the office. You took the board. You took the South expansion. You took everything he had to give." He looked at his hands, at the red dust under his nails. "And now he is gone."

Vikram didn't go to the city office the next day, or the week after that. He stayed in the house, sitting in the small room off the kitchen.

Reddy came twice. Sinha came once. They sat in the drawing room, drank the tea Ramu brought, and talked about the transition of power.

"We need signatures, Vikram," Reddy said during the second visit. "The Nandyal plant phase two needs approval. The banks are waiting."

"Ask Rohan to sign," Vikram said.

Reddy laughed, a short, dry sound. "Rohan? He is an engineer, Vikram. The board won't accept his signature on a financial release."

"They will," Vikram said. "If he owns the shares."

Reddy stopped laughing, his eyes narrowing. "What are you saying?"

"Prepare the transfer documents," Vikram said. "The shares, the house, the Odisha license. Everything Binay Ahuja left behind. Transfer it all to Rohan."

"You are out of your mind," Reddy said, standing up. "He cannot run this. He doesn't know the distributors. He doesn't know the MLA."

"He will learn," Vikram said. "I learned."

The lawyer brought the transfer papers on Friday afternoon. The study room was hot, and Ramu had forgotten to turn on the cooler.

Rohan stood near the desk, but he didn't touch the pen. "Why are you doing this, Vikram?"

"Because you want it," Vikram said.

"I didn't ask for a gift."

"It's not a gift," Vikram said. "It is what is yours."

He picked up the pen and signed first. His signature had become neat over the ten years, the letters even, the 'A' sharp and clear. He set the pen down.

"The driver is waiting outside," Vikram said. "The keys to the city office are on the table."

Rohan looked at the signed papers. His hand trembled slightly as he picked up the pen to sign below Vikram's name. He didn't look at his brother.

"Where will you go?" Rohan asked, his voice low.

"Sarita's place," Vikram said. "Near the bypass."

Rohan's pen stopped. "The AIDS shelter?"

"Yes."

"People will talk, Vikram. They will say I pushed you out."

"Let them," Vikram said. "They have been talking since 1995. It is their business."

He picked up his small leather bag from the floor. It contained two shirts, one pair of trousers, and nothing else.

He walked out of the study. He didn't use the main gate.

He walked through the kitchen, passed Ramu who was still sorting cardamoms, and went out of the green side gate.

The road outside was dusty, and the afternoon sun was direct and sharp. He didn't call a cab. He walked toward the bypass, his bag in his left hand, his face toward the heat.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

The Punarjeevan shelter had no gatekeeper. The rusted iron gate sat half-open, held in place by an old red brick to keep it from swinging in the constant dust kicked up by the trucks on the nearby bypass road.

Vikram had walked four kilometers down the highway before a truck driver offered him a lift on a flatbed carrying concrete pipes. He sat on the wooden bench of the driver's cabin, the smell of grease and raw diesel filling his lungs, saying nothing until the driver let him off near the bypass milestone.

Sarita was sitting in the front courtyard under the thin shade of a drumstick tree. She had a large red plastic tub of dry chillies in her lap, sorting the split ones from the whole with practiced, rhythmic movements.

Her saree was made of faded cotton, the color of wet river brick. She didn't look up when the gate creaked on its hinges.

"We don't have visitor hours on Friday," she said, her hands moving through the pile.

"I am not a visitor," Vikram said, carrying his leather bag.

She stopped sorting the chillies, the red dust rising in the hot air. She looked at his leather bag, then down at his dusty leather shoes.

"Rohan signed?" she asked.

"He signed."

"And you?"

"I signed first," Vikram said.

Sarita went back to the chillies, making a dry, rustling sound as she moved them. "This is not a guesthouse, Mr. Ahuja. We don't have city comforts here."

"I know."

"We don't have clean sheets. We don't have separate rooms. The men sleep in the side hall—six on the floor, and one on the wooden bench near the window."

"I can sleep on the floor," Vikram said, setting his bag down on the stone verandah.

She stood up, placing the plastic tub on the stone ledge of the well. Her hands were slightly red from the dry chilli dust.

"You are thirty-five," she said, looking him directly in the eye. "Same age as me. You have sat in a leather executive chair for ten years. You think this is a retreat. A peace-finding exercise to feel good."

"No," Vikram said.

"It isn't," she said, her voice dropping. "The municipal corporation cuts our water line twice a month because we don't pay the grease money. The local school refuses our children. And three times a year, someone dies in the back room and we have to argue with the local police to let us bury them without a post-mortem."

She wiped her hands on the edge of her saree. "I have the virus, Vikram. I have had it for six years. My husband gave it to me before he died. Most people in this house have it. You don't."

"I know," Vikram said.

"Then why are you standing at my gate with nothing but two shirts in a bag?"

"Because nobody here calls me Ahuja Sahib," Vikram said.

Sarita studied his face for a long moment. The hot wind from the bypass brought the dry smell of burnt rubber from the tyre repair shops down the road.

"Go to the well," she said finally, her voice softening. "Wash the dust off. Ramu's nephew brings the tea at five. It is cheap tea. We don't have sugar today, only jaggery."

The well water was cold. Vikram drew a bucket, the rough hemp rope biting against his palms.

He washed his face, his neck, and his arms, the dust of the Nandyal roads and the study room sliding off his skin into the drain.

A girl was standing near the drumstick tree, watching him. She was thin, wearing an oversized blue frock that had a small tear near the hem, and her hair was tied in two tight plates.

She looked fourteen, perhaps fifteen, her collarbones standing out sharp under the thin fabric.

"You are the factory man," she said, her voice direct.

"My name is Vikram," he said, wiping his face with his sleeve.

"Sarita didi said you own the big trucks."

"My brother owns them now," Vikram said.

She came closer. Her eyes were large, dark, and had the specific, unblinking curiosity of a child who had grown up around adults who had stopped hiding things from her.

"I am Ananya," she said.

"Do you go to school, Ananya?"

"The school closed for me," she said, without any sadness in her voice. "They said my blood is bad."

"Who said that?"

"The headmaster. He told Sarita didi that if I sit near the other girls, their parents will stop paying the fees. Sarita didi argued. She has a very loud voice when she's angry. But the gate remained locked."

She looked at his leather bag near the well. "What is inside?"

"Two shirts," Vikram said.

"No toys?"

"No."

He glanced at his bag near the well. Two shirts. That was all.

"I have a wooden horse," she said proudly. "Ramu's nephew made it. It has only three legs, but it stands if you lean it against the wall."

Vikram smiled. It was the first real smile since the doctor's phone call at four in the morning. "Show me," he said.

They sat on the low stone wall of the well. The wooden horse was small, carved from a dry branch of the drumstick tree.

Ananya leaned it carefully against the bucket. It stood.

"See?" she said, pointing at it. "It doesn't need the fourth leg. It is just for show."

Sarita came out carrying a steel kettle and three mismatched glasses. She set them on the stone ledge.

The tea was dark red. No milk. The jaggery had turned it the color of boiled tamarind.

"Drink," she said.

Vikram held the glass. The heat of the glass was direct, burning his fingers slightly. He took a sip.

The jaggery was sweet, but the tea was strong and bitter at the edges. Outside, the bypass traffic went on, the trucks honking, the dust rising.

But inside the courtyard, the red tea tasted of nothing but the well water and the shade of the drumstick tree.

"It is good," Vikram said.

Sarita sat on the well wall beside Ananya. She put her arm around the girl's shoulder, pulling her close.

"It is cheap," Sarita said, looking at the road. "But it is ours."

Vikram drank. He looked at the three-legged horse, at Ananya's laughter as she knocked it down and set it up again, and at Sarita's quiet face.

The fourteen hundred crore had gone to Nandyal. The office keys were left on the teak wood desk.

But the red tea in his glass smelled better than any tea he had ever had in a boardroom.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

The shelter ran on a completely different kind of math. In the city head office, Vikram had spent his days watching ledger entries balance down to the single paisa.

Here, a single sack of potatoes was expected to stretch for nine days, but occasionally it stretched for eleven because Ramu's nephew had brought three heads of cauliflower that had gone slightly soft at the edges and were given as a gift.

Vikram's job was the water. Every morning at five, before the trucks on the bypass started their high-pitched honking, he drew twelve buckets from the stone well.

The first six went to the kitchen for cooking. The next four went to the washing area behind the storage drums. The last two he kept near the drumstick trees for the children's morning wash.

His hands, which had gone soft from ten years of holding executive pens and checking ledgers, grew a thin, rough layer of yellow calluses along the base of his fingers.

"You are drawing that bucket too fast," Sarita told him one morning.

She was sitting on the brick steps of the verandah, using a piece of broken glass to scrape the dried mud off a pair of old rubber sandals.

"The rope will slip," she said.

"The rope is new," Vikram said, pulling the bucket over the iron pulley.

"Ropes don't care if they are new, Vikram," she said, without looking up. "They slip when they are tired."

She went back to the sandals. She looked tired herself, her cheeks having gone slightly hollow over the last two weeks, her eyes carrying the grey shadow that came when the medicine from the government hospital didn't suit her stomach.

She never mentioned her pain. But Vikram had started noticing the exact hour she went to her room to lie down. It was always three in the afternoon, when the heat of the tiled roof was the worst.

Ananya sat on the low wall of the well, her thin legs swinging over the side. She was holding a notebook Vikram had bought for her from the bypass store.

"What is this word?" she asked, pointing her pencil at the page.

"Equation," Vikram said, looking over her shoulder.

"What does it mean?"

"It means two sides have to be equal. What you put on the left must match what is on the right."

She thought for a moment, the tip of her pencil touching her lip. "Like a balance scale?"

"Yes."

"But if you put something on one side, and the other side has nothing, what happens then?"

"It tilts," Vikram said.

"Then it is not an equation."

"No."

She closed the notebook with a soft thud. "My school had a big blackboard. The teacher had three colors of chalk. Yellow, pink, and white. She only used the pink one when someone got the answer wrong."

"Which color did she use for you?"

"White," Ananya said, looking at the drumstick leaves. "I didn't get the answers wrong. I just had the bad blood."

She hopped off the wall. "Let's make the tea. Ramu's nephew brought the ginger today."

"What is your name?" Vikram asked, though he already knew.

"Ananya," she said, looking back briefly.

He had known another Ananya once. The name sat in his mouth for a second before he swallowed it back down and said nothing.

The tea stall near the bypass was run by a man named Shankar. He had one wooden bench that sat in the dusty shade of a large hoarding advertising cement.

Vikram and Ananya walked there in the evenings. It wasn't because the shelter tea wasn't enough; it was because Shankar's stall was the only place where the truck drivers and the local laborers sat together without asking who had what.

They sat on the wooden bench, their backs to the cement advertisement. Shankar served the tea in small glass tumblers.

Red tea. It was strong, sweet with local palm jaggery, smelling of the dry mud of the roadside and the diesel exhaust of the passing carriers.

"Your brother came to the factory yesterday," Shankar said, wiping a glass with a dirty rag.

Vikram looked at the road. A multi-axle truck carrying iron ore was moving slowly, its gears groaning under the weight.

"Reddy garu was with him," Shankar continued. "They had three cars. The big white one."

"Rohan likes the white one," Vikram said.

"People say he is very strict. He fined two loaders for being ten minutes late yesterday morning."

Vikram took a sip of his tea. The jaggery was burnt at the bottom, leaving a bitter, sweet crust on the edge of the glass.

Ananya was watching a puppy playing near the tyre shop across the road.

"Let him be strict," Vikram said. "A new house needs a strong door."

"But you," Shankar said, looking at Vikram's faded cotton shirt. "You were the Ahuja saab. People used to stand up when your car passed the crossing."

"They still stand," Vikram said, smiling. "To cross the road."

Shankar laughed, a loud sound. He wiped the same glass a second time, which is what he did when something was on his mind.

"There was a Municipal Corporation jeep near your gate this morning," he said, not quite asking. "Early. Before the morning walkers."

Vikram looked at the road.

"The driver didn't stop," Shankar continued. "Just looked at the building, wrote something on a clipboard, and turned back toward the highway."

"It is nothing," Vikram said.

Shankar put the glass down. He didn't argue, which meant he wasn't sure.

They walked back to the shelter as the sun was setting behind the bypass hills. The sky had gone the color of a bruised plum.

Ananya was walking ahead of him, balancing herself on the concrete edge of the open drain.

"Vikram," she called.

"Yes?"

"When the school starts again, will you teach me the pink chalk words?"

"Yes," Vikram said.

"Even the ones that are wrong?"

"Especially those," Vikram said.

She smiled, her tight hair plates swinging as she ran a few steps ahead.

At the shelter gate, the brick was still holding the iron grill open. The smell of Ramu's nephew's wood fire was coming from the kitchen—dry wood, slightly damp from the evening dew, mixing with the smell of the red tea they had left behind at the bypass.

He walked inside. The red tea was waiting.

[End of Part 3]

CHAPTER V: THE YELLOW ENVELOPE

PART 1

*The bulldozer was yellow, with a dented steel bucket that had **Escorts** painted in peeling red letters on the side. It sat parked near the shelter's outer gate for three days before it actually started working.*

The driver spent the first two days sleeping in the cabin, his bare legs dangling out of the open door, his dirty shirt thrown over the black steering wheel to block the afternoon sun.

On the third morning, the municipal junior engineer arrived in a green jeep. He didn't bother to get down.

He simply waved a damp blue paper toward Sarita, who was standing near the well holding a plastic bucket. "Road widening," he shouted over the loud rumble of the jeep's engine. "Clear the rooms by twelve o'clock."

"We have fourteen patients in there," Sarita said, her voice steady. "Three of them cannot walk."

"The demolition order was signed in March, sister," the engineer said, checking his watch. "The contractor is paying daily rent on the machine. Twelve o'clock is the hard deadline."

He turned the jeep around, the tyres throwing up a thick cloud of dust. The dust settled on the nearby drumstick trees, turning the green leaves a dull, powdery grey.

Vikram had walked to the local post office to call Rohan. He dialled the office number twice from the coin-box phone, his fingers smelling of iron.

Both times, the receptionist's voice had come through the heavy static of the long-distance line, polite and completely unyielding.

"Ahuja saab is in a board meeting. Leave a message."

"Tell him it's Vikram."

"Yes, sir. I have noted it in the ledger," she said, her voice remote.

He didn't call a third time. He hung up the black receiver, took his change, and walked back to the shelter.

At eleven-thirty, the steel bucket of the yellow bulldozer touched the outer courtyard wall. There was a low, grating sound of dry mortar giving way as the bricks crumbled.

Ananya stood near the kitchen door. She was holding her wooden horse and the school notebook with the white chalk drawings.

She wasn't crying. She looked at the heavy yellow machine with the same unblinking, serious curiosity she had used for the maths equations.

"It is very loud," she said, looking up at Vikram.

"Yes," Vikram said.

"Will they break the well too?"

"Yes."

She nodded. She walked to his side, her small hand finding the side pocket of his faded cotton shirt and holding onto the fabric. "Where will we sleep tonight?"

"Kolkata," Vikram said.

The train was the Howrah Express. They had three third-class compartments, the tickets bought with the last eight thousand rupees Sarita had kept in the shelter's steel tin box.

The patients sat near the windows, their thin, fever-flushed faces drawing the immediate attention of the vendors selling tea and peanuts at every station.

An old woman with a severe cough kept her face covered with her cotton saree border. A passenger from the middle berth looked down, saw her thin, scarred wrists, and quietly moved his leather luggage to the upper rack.

He didn't say a word. Neither did Sarita.

She sat opposite Vikram, her forehead pressed against the cold iron bars of the window. The fever had returned.

Her skin was hot to the touch, dry and paper-thin in the afternoon heat. "The house belongs to my late husband's uncle," she said. Her voice was thin, dry like the warm breeze blowing through the train window. "He died in ninety-two. The sons went to Delhi. Nobody has lived there for twenty years."

"Is there a well?" Vikram asked.

"A municipal tap," she said. "In the corner of the courtyard. And three big neem trees. The leaves are good for cooling the skin."

She closed her eyes. "It is in Bagbazar. Near the river. The wind smells of wet jute and river mud."

Vikram looked out at the passing landscape. The green paddy fields of Odisha were slowly giving way to the grey marshlands and brick kilns of Bengal.

The iron wheels of the train kept up their rhythmic, metallic clank.

Fourteen hundred.

Fourteen hundred.

Fourteen hundred.

The number didn't have the same sound in his head anymore. It was just noise.

The house in Bagbazar had a large wooden door that had swollen from the monsoon damp, refusing to open more than a foot. Vikram had to shoulder it twice, the old iron lock cracking inside the wood with a sharp

sound like dry bone breaking.

The air inside the house was thick and heavy. It smelled of bat droppings, wet lime, and the cold, unventilated damp of twenty years of shadow.

The plaster had fallen off the walls in large, curved sheets, showing the thin red bricks underneath. A courtyard sat in the middle, three neem trees growing wild, their thick roots lifting the old stone tiles at strange angles.

An old marble nameplate near the entrance read: **Sen family. 1924.**

Ananya walked in first, her plastic sandals making clean prints in the thick grey dust that covered the stone floor. "It has many rooms," she said, looking up.

"Eleven," Sarita said, leaning against the door frame to catch her breath. She looked at the courtyard, at the dry neem leaves that had piled up in the corners. "The tap is in the corner," she said, pointing to a rusted iron pipe rising from the stone floor.

Vikram went to the tap. He turned the heavy brass handle.

A dry squeak echoed through the courtyard. Then, a thin stream of orange, rust-stained water came out, sputtering before it went clear and cold.

He drew a handful. It tasted of iron and river sand.

He washed his face. The water felt different from the Odisha well. It was heavier, older.

Sarita sat on the lowest step of the verandah, her head resting against the wooden pillar that had been eaten away by termites near the base. "We will start with the front room," she said. "Sweep the dust. The patients are waiting at the crossing with the luggage."

Vikram picked up a broom he had bought at the station. The bamboo bristles were stiff, scratching the old stone floor with a sharp, dry sound.

Ananya sat near the well tap, setting her three-legged horse on a clean stone she had wiped with her skirt. It stood.

"See?" she said, pointing. "It works here too."

Vikram began to sweep. The dust rose in the afternoon sun, turning the shafts of light into columns of moving, grey sand.

He swept the first room, then the second. His hands, already hard from the well rope of Odisha, didn't feel the rough bamboo handle anymore.

On the third morning, he went to fill the bucket at the courtyard tap and found a frog in the well.

It was sitting on the rough stone rim at the bottom, two feet below the waterline, on the only dry ledge in the circular shaft. The well was only six feet deep—it had probably not been a true working well in years, more of a drain—but for a frog, six feet of wet stone with no grip is effectively the end of the world.

Vikram looked at it for a moment. Then he went and got the bucket and the rope.

The frog was not cooperative. Every time the bucket touched the water near the ledge, the frog moved two inches sideways, keeping its distance with the dignified caution of a creature that has been near the bottom for long enough to distrust anything coming from above.

Vikram lowered the bucket twice. The frog did not enter it.

He lowered a folded piece of jute cloth tied to the rope. The frog ignored it.

He spent eleven minutes on this. Sarita came out of the kitchen at some point and stood on the verandah step, watching. She had the look of someone who already knew the answer and had decided not to ruin the exercise by saying so.

On the twelfth minute, the frog, apparently reconsidering its position on its own terms, hopped onto the hanging cloth. Vikram drew it up slowly, hand over hand, the wet rope marking his palms. The frog sat on the cloth with the patience of something that has made a decision and is no longer nervous about it.

Vikram lifted it over the stone lip of the well and set the cloth on the courtyard floor.

The frog sat still for a moment. Then it took two hops toward the neem-root crack in the corner tile.

A crow, which had been sitting on the neem branch above since before Vikram had even picked up the rope, dropped from the branch in a single clean movement, picked the frog off the stone in its beak, and flew back up to its branch.

The whole thing took perhaps two seconds.

Vikram stood at the well with the empty jute cloth still in his hands.

Sarita, from the verandah, said: "It was safer in the water."

He looked up. She was completely serious, her bamboo cane resting against the pillar, her eyes on the crow.

Vikram looked at the crow. He looked at the empty courtyard floor where the frog had been. Then he laughed, a real laugh, the first one in some weeks.

"In college," he said, "we rescued five chickens from the canteen behind the hostel. Set them free at midnight. By the next afternoon, four of them were dead or sold to a dhaba, and one was sitting in the Registrar's garden eating marigolds."

Sarita considered this. "And the moral?"

"I asked Adarsh the same thing at the time," Vikram said, dropping the cloth over the well rim. "He said there wasn't one. I think he was right."

Sarita picked up her cane and went back into the kitchen. From inside, she said: "Start with the back room next. The bat droppings are worst in there."

He picked up the broom.

He had left the boardrooms. He had left the big white cars. He had left the name that opened gates.

The iron-tasting water of the Bagbazar tap felt like exactly enough.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

By the winter of 2015, the name **Punarjeevan** was painted on the main wooden door in clean, black Bengali script.

The wood of the frame had stopped swelling. Vikram had planed the damp edges himself, using a small steel block plane he had bought from a hardware market near the Shobhabazar crossing.

The house had become clean, the bat droppings swept away, and the courtyard tiles carefully reset on a bed of fresh lime. They had twenty-two beds now, and the front rooms were always full.

Sarita's fever came less often, but she had started using a walking stick. It was a simple bamboo cane, identical to the one Vikram had left beside the ICU door in Odisha, except this one had no red cloth tied at the top.

Ananya was seventeen now. She had grown tall, her hair no longer in tight plates, but tied in a single ponytail with a thick black rubber band.

She spent her mornings at the register table near the main entrance, writing the new patient entries in a ledger that had a green cloth cover. Her handwriting had become neat, the letters upright and small, just like the notes Vikram had written for her on the stone steps years ago.

The courier arrived at twelve. He didn't walk inside; he stood at the threshold, his bicycle leaning against the courtyard wall, holding a long yellow envelope in his hand.

"Vikram Ahuja?" the courier asked, looking at the ledger table.

Vikram, who was clearing dead neem leaves from the courtyard drain with a wire rake, stood up and wiped his hands. "Yes."

"Registered post. From Cuttack. Forwarded from Bhubaneswar," the courier said, handing him the slip to sign.

The postmarks on the yellow paper were overlapping, three circles of purple ink, one of them showing the date: **12-10-15.**

Vikram signed the delivery slip. The paper of the envelope was cheap and rough to the touch, the yellow color slightly faded at the corners where the glue had dried.

He sat on the lowest step of the verandah. In the kitchen, the smell of boiling rice and cumin came through the open wooden window.

He tore the top of the envelope.

The letter inside was written on two sheets of cheap, ruled paper.

Before he had read past the second line, Ramu's nephew came to the verandah doorway with a question about the afternoon medicine delivery. Vikram waved his hand without looking up. The boy waited, then went back inside.

He returned to the letter from the beginning, his eyes moving quickly now, the way you read something when you are already forming its meaning in your head before the words confirm it.

The handwriting was small and the letters rounded, with a careful spacing he had seen somewhere before—on drafts of something, somewhere, in another life.

Vikram,

I don't know if this will reach you.

After Odisha, I married Rashid. He asked me to convert. I did. He named the child Rehman.

Then he left. Another woman. Another city. No address.

I have been alone since.

Rehman is nineteen. He is nothing like me. He wants to do the kind of work you do. He saw your name somewhere and has not stopped asking about you.

I told him you walked away from everything.

He said: that is the right direction.

He will arrive tomorrow on the Howrah passenger.

I am not asking for forgiveness. Some things cannot be returned.

Ira.

Vikram sat there on the step, the paper light in his fingers. The neem leaves in the courtyard moved slightly in the warm wind, making a dry, whispering sound against the stone tiles.

He looked at the yellow envelope again. The paper was cheap, the kind sold at railway station stalls for ten paise.

"Who was it?" Sarita asked, coming out of the kitchen with a plate of sliced cucumbers. She sat on the step beside him, her bamboo cane resting against her knee.

"A letter," Vikram said.

"From Odisha?"

"From Ira," Vikram said.

Sarita didn't ask who Ira was. Some names don't need a designation when you have lived with a man's silence in the same house for three years.

"What does she want?" Sarita asked, picking up a slice of cucumber.

"Her son is coming tomorrow," Vikram said. "He wants to work here at the shelter."

Sarita looked at the courtyard well. "We have room. We always have room for someone who has nowhere else to go."

Vikram folded the paper carefully and put it back into the yellow envelope. The postmark was still purple, dry and clear under the grey light of the Bagbazar sky.

He kept it in his shirt pocket. He could feel it through the cotton as he went back to clearing the drain.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

The boy arrived at three in the afternoon, when the shadows of the neem trees had stretched fully across the stones of the courtyard well.

He was carrying a cheap blue canvas bag with a rusted zip that didn't go all the way to the end, showing a corner of a grey towel inside. His shoes were cheap black canvas, the rubber soles worn thin, with a line of grey station dust outlining the seams near his toes.

*He stood near the swollen wooden entrance door. He didn't knock; he simply stood there, his hands holding the faded canvas straps of the bag, looking up at the marble nameplate **Sen family** with the quiet concentration of a passenger checking a train ticket.*

Vikram heard a voice from the register table — Ananya, asking something — and then the boy's reply, soft, an Odia accent in it. He came out of the back room carrying a heavy plastic bucket of white lime wash.

He set the bucket down on the stone verandah.

The boy looked at Vikram's face, his eyes moving slowly from the white splash on the temple to the faded cotton shirt, and then down to his calloused hands. Then he bowed slightly, his hands folding near his chest in a respectful gesture.

"Vikram uncle?"

"Yes," Vikram said, wiping his brow with his arm.

"I am Rehman," the boy said.

Vikram looked at the boy's eyes. They were large, dark, and the shape of the eyelids was identical to the ones that had watched him in the Salt Lake newspaper office ten years ago.

But they had none of her nervous restlessness; they were still and calm.

"Your train was on time?" Vikram asked.

"Two hours late at Howrah," the boy said, shifting his bag. "I took the local bus to the Bagbazar crossing, and the conductor showed me the lane."

Sarita came out of the hallway, leaning on her bamboo cane. She looked at the boy and his small canvas bag. Vikram remembered her saying something about the dal, something about Ramesh's old bed in the side hall. The boy had nodded. Later, Sarita told him she had taken one look at the boy's shoes — the rubber soles worn down to almost nothing — and decided the rest immediately.

He washed at the municipal tap. He drew the water with one hand, his canvas bag kept carefully on the stone ledge near Ananya's table.

Vikram watched him from the verandah steps. The boy's neck was thin, the vertebrae standing out under the collar of his faded blue shirt as he bent over the iron pipe.

He washed his face twice, using a small piece of red soap he had brought in his bag. It was the cheap, local brand of soap sold at the small station shops in Cuttack.

He wiped his face with a small green hand towel, then walked back to the steps. "Where is the work, uncle?" he asked.

"The work is everywhere," Vikram said. "Today, we are whitewashing the kitchen wall. Tomorrow, the medicine delivery arrives from the college hospital."

"I can do the whitewashing," the boy said.

He picked up the spare brush leaning near the bucket. He didn't ask how to hold it, and he didn't ask where he should start.

He simply went to the kitchen door, looked at the grey patch on the wall where the plaster had been repaired, and began to paint.

His strokes were slow, slightly uneven at first, but he didn't stop until the grey brick was covered in clean, flat white.

Vikram stood beside him, taking the second brush from the bucket. For one hour, they painted the kitchen wall together in silence, the smell of fresh lime and damp brick rising between them in the small room.

Outside, the afternoon light faded slowly. The shadow of the neem trees covered the well.

Ananya sat at her table, her pen moving regularly as she entered the evening medicines in the green cloth ledger.

At five, Ramu's nephew brought the steel kettle. It was red tea.

Shankar's jaggery was gone, but Sarita had bought a small cone of palm sugar from the market. They sat on the verandah steps, three mismatched glasses between them.

"It is good tea," Rehman said, blowing on the hot glass.

"It is cheap," Sarita said, sitting near Ananya's table. "But it keeps us warm."

The boy drank. He looked at the neem trees, at the old marble nameplate, and then at the white kitchen wall he had painted.

Ananya kept her eyes on the green cloth ledger. Her pen continued moving at the same pace it had before the tea arrived.

Vikram noticed this, but it didn't register as odd at the time.

"My mother told me," Rehman said, his voice quiet. "She said you were a tycoon once."

Vikram looked down at his glass. The red tea was hot, the palm sugar sweet and dark.

"She was mistaken," Vikram said. "I was never a tycoon."

The boy smiled. It was a small, quiet smile that had nothing of the boardroom in it, and nothing of the city.

"I know," Rehman said. "The tycoon would never have painted the kitchen."

Vikram drank his tea. The Bagbazar tap water was heavy, but the red tea tasted of the fresh lime on his brush and the neem leaves in the wind.

He looked at the yellow envelope sitting on the study table inside. The envelope was closed, the boy was here, and as the night settled over the Sen family house, the red tea in his hand was enough.

[End of Part 3]

CHAPTER VI: THE GREEN LAWN

PART 1

The park bench was made of iron slats painted a bright green. The paint had blistered from the heavy Kolkata summer heat, peeling away in long, curved strips that looked like dried snake skins resting on the grass.

It sat in the middle of Bagbazar park under the shade of a large banyan tree, whose thick aerial roots had grown down to touch the soil, enclosing the bench on three sides like a wooden cage.

Vikram sat there in the mornings, watching the early walkers. He had started sitting on the bench after Sarita left for Delhi with five of the patients who had recovered enough to help her set up a new shelter home near the airport.

"Rehman will handle the Bagbazar house," Sarita had told Vikram before she boarded the train. "He has the entire ledger in his head, Vikram. He knows which distributor is late and which water tap is leaking in the washroom."

"I am here," Vikram had said.

"You are here physically, yes," she had said, leaning on her bamboo cane. "But your mind is still sweeping the dust. Let the boy manage the numbers. He likes them, and he is good at it."

He was.

Rehman brought the ledger register to the park bench at eleven. He sat on the hot iron slats beside Vikram, keeping his blue canvas bag between his feet.

He was twenty-two years old now. His shoulders had gone wider, and his jaw carried the sharp, dry line of an adult who spent more time talking to bank managers and suppliers than to the patients.

He wore a clean, white khadi kurta, but his shoes were still the same cheap canvas, now grey with Kolkata mud.

"The donations are not enough, uncle," Rehman said, looking at the road.

"They are enough for the paracetamol and the dal," Vikram said.

"But not for the new medical kits. The government supply is three weeks late, and the local supplier wants twelve percent interest on the credit. I told him he is a thief, but he said the bank doesn't accept moral arguments on unpaid bills."

He closed the register, the thick cover making a soft slap. The green cloth of the cover had gone dark near the edges from where his palms had rested during the long hours.

"We need a brand," Rehman said.

"A brand is for businesses, Rehman. This is a shelter."

"If we have to beg for every single rupee of medicine, we are not truly helping, uncle," Rehman said, his voice rising slightly in the quiet park. "We are just waiting for rich men to feel guilty on their birthdays and write us cheques."

"What would you do?" Vikram asked.

"Make our own products," Rehman said, his eyes bright. "The patients here have hands. They can pack medical kits for the clinics. They can make incense sticks from the temple flowers Ramu's nephew brings. Simple things."

He leaned forward, resting his elbows on his knees, looking at Vikram.

"Greed is bad, uncle. My mother taught me that. But need is not bad. If we have to buy paracetamol, we need money. If we have to fight the municipal clerks for the water connection, we need power. Why should the devils have all the money and do what they want, while we stay small and sweep the dust?"

Vikram looked at the banyan roots. A row of red ants was moving along a split in the dark bark, carrying a single grain of white sugar.

"Power is a heavy thing to hold, Rehman," Vikram said.

"It is only heavy when you carry it alone," the boy said. "We will carry it together. The patients will make the incense in the courtyard, and I will sell it to the local distributors."

He stood up, adjusting his white bag. "I have already decided on the name."

"What name?"

"Ummed," Rehman said. "It means hope."

Vikram's hand stopped on the iron slat of the bench, his fingers freezing.

Ummed. The name had the soft, Urdu sound of a letter written on ruled paper from Cuttack years ago. **He changed my name to Ummed.**

He looked at Rehman. The boy was looking up at the banyan leaves, his face clear, his smile open and free of the Odisha dust.

"It is my mother's name," Rehman said. "She told me once that when everything is lost, only Ummed remains."

"It is a Muslim name," Vikram said.

"She converted," the boy said, without looking back. "But the meaning didn't change."

He picked up his canvas bag. "I will print the first labels today. Simple yellow paper. Like the yellow envelope my mother sent."

He walked away down the gravel path of the park. Vikram sat on the bench alone.

The green paint felt hot under his fingers, but the name **Ummed** was still sitting on the grass between the banyan roots, unmoving and growing in the warm air.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

By 2022, the **Ummid** brand had moved from yellow paper labels to professional, printed cardboard boxes. The incense sticks were sold in three states, the medical kits were distributed to ninety-two municipal health centers, and the sanitary pads were manufactured in three separate units near Barasat.

The financial newspapers wrote the numbers: **Seventy-six hundred crore.**

Vikram didn't read the papers. He still slept in the side room of the Bagbazar house, on the same wooden bench he had claimed when they first arrived from the bypass.

His clothes were still three faded cotton shirts, washed every morning at the courtyard tap and hung to dry on the line under the neem trees.

Rehman had moved out of the Bagbazar house. He had rented a large apartment in Alipore, with a uniformed security guard at the gate and a silver sedan that was cleaned twice a day by a boy he paid five hundred rupees a month.

He had traveled to Geneva twice for international NGO conferences. His white kurtas were made of expensive silk now, and his old canvas shoes had been replaced by black leather loafers that had no mud on the soles.

"You should come to the Alipore house, uncle," Rehman had told him during a visit. "It has modern air conditioning. The city summer is bad for your lungs."

"My lungs are used to the neem leaves," Vikram said, looking at the courtyard.

The celebration party was held in the lawn of a heritage hotel near the river Hooghly.

Sarita had returned from New York for the event. She had successfully set up the US fundraising branch, **Punarjeevan International**, which had raised six million dollars in its very first quarter.

The lawn was lit with hundreds of small yellow bulbs hung from the branches of the old mango trees. Seventy people had arrived—three local MLAs, two bank directors, and a group of journalists from the city's business desks.

Sarita sat in a comfortable cane armchair near the catering tables, her bamboo walking stick leaning against her knee. She looked thinner, but her eyes were bright in the warm light.

"The numbers are huge, Vikram," she said as he stood beside her.

"Yes," Vikram said.

"Rehman did it," she whispered. "He worked eighteen hours a day when I was in New York. He didn't sleep for a week during the Barasat license crisis."

"I know," Vikram said.

A local MLA approached them, holding a glass of apple juice. "Ahuja saab," he said, bowing slightly to Vikram. "Congratulations. What a massive vision. From Odisha to this. Only an Ahuja could have built a

service empire this large."

*Vikram didn't bother to correct him. He had tried correcting people for five years, but they simply smiled, nodded, and went on writing **Ahuja** in the press reports anyway.*

Rehman was standing three feet away, talking to a bank manager. His glass was whiskey, the ice cubes clicking against the crystal.

He had heard the MLA's words. He didn't turn around, but his shoulders went rigid under his silk kurta, his hand tightening around the glass until his knuckles went white.

The terrace of the heritage hotel was dark. Vikram had gone up there to escape the loud noise of the catering staff clearing plates in the lawn below.

The river Hooghly was visible between the concrete warehouses, the water black, reflecting the distant yellow lamps of the Howrah bridge.

Rehman's footsteps were heavy on the brick floor of the terrace. He was carrying his whiskey glass, which was now empty.

"They only see you," Rehman said, his voice thick. The smell of alcohol was strong on his breath, mixing with the damp smell of river mud rising from the bank.

"Rehman," Vikram said.

"No," the boy said, walking closer. "Don't say it, uncle. Don't say 'it doesn't matter.' It matters to me."

He looked out at the dark river. "I did the licenses. I did the banking. I did the travel. I lived in cheap hotels that smelled of insecticide for three years to set up the Barasat factory."

He turned to Vikram, his face red in the distant light from the bridge, his eyes wet.

*"And the MLA comes and says: **Only an Ahuja could do this.** What is an Ahuja? A name? A legacy? Just because your father was rich?"*

"He didn't know the details, Rehman," Vikram said.

"Nobody knows!" Rehman shouted, his voice echoing off the brick parapet. His glass slipped from his fingers, hitting the floor and cracking with a sharp, dry sound.

"I am the candle, uncle. I burn myself to give the light. And everyone turns their face to the sun."

He walked to the edge of the terrace, his hands gripping the iron railing. "Is it because of my name? Because I am Rehman? Because my mother converted? Because we had no wealth or house in Odisha?"

Vikram stood behind him. "You built this, Rehman. The board knows. Sarita knows."

"But the world doesn't," the boy said, his voice dropping to a whisper. "I wanted to show them. I wanted to show my mother that I am not the spare. That I can build something bigger than what was taken from us."

He looked back at Vikram. "But I cannot. Not as long as you are standing in the doorway."

He walked past Vikram, his leather loafers making a sharp, clean sound on the brick floor. "I am going to Alipore," he said, without looking back.

Vikram stood alone on the dark terrace. The broken glass of Rehman's whiskey cup was catching the distant light of the bridge.

The wind from the river was cold. But as he looked at the dark water, the fourteen hundred crore and the seventy-six hundred crore felt like the same thing—a weight he was still carrying, even when he had nothing left in his pockets.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

The lawyer's name was Bannerjee. He had a small, dusty office in Dalhousie Square that smelled of red tape, old cardboard, and damp sheepskin folders.

He arrived at the Bagbazar house on a Saturday morning, his black leather briefcase bulging with three copies of the corporate transfer deed.

He set the briefcase down on the register table with the careful deliberateness of a man transporting something fragile. Then he opened it, removed the three copies, and arranged them in a row by size. He patted each one once.

"Three copies," he said, to nobody in particular. "The Registrar's office in Dalhousie Square has, in my twenty-two years of practice, never once failed to lose the original. So. Three."

"This is the second time we are doing this, Vikram babu," Bannerjee said, setting the thick papers on the green register table.

Ananya was standing near the well, holding her broom. She had stopped sweeping and was looking at the white paper documents, her eyes moving slowly from the lawyer's clean cuffs to Vikram's hand.

"The second time is easier," Vikram said, picking up the pen.

"It is never easier," Bannerjee said. "The first time, it was family. Your brother Rohan. This time, it is an employee—a boy who has been here only four years. The board will ask questions. The international donors will want to know why the founder is walking away."

"The founder is tired," Vikram said.

He signed. His signature didn't have the sharp, clear 'A' it used to have in Odisha. It was looser, the ink from the ballpoint pen running slightly at the edge of the 'V', leaving a small blue blur on the white bond paper.

Ramu's nephew brought the tea in mismatched glasses. It was red tea, but today the palm sugar was missing from the kitchen; it was just hot ginger and water.

Bannerjee drank his tea quickly, packed the signed deeds into his leather bag, and stood up. "Rehman has the power now. The banking, the Barasat unit, the international funds. He is the CEO."

"Good," Vikram said.

Vikram fell sick three days later. It was the winter cough, the cold fog from the Hooghly river settling deep in his chest, making every breath sound like the dry regulator hiss from his father's room.

He stayed on his wooden bench in the side room, staring at the ceiling. Sarita brought him hot barley water twice a day, her cane tapping on the stone floor.

"Rehman hasn't come," she said on the fourth morning, setting the cup on the stool.

"He is busy with the Barasat audit, Sarita," Vikram said.

"He is in Alipore, Vikram. The office supervisor said the silver sedan was parked outside the administrative building for three hours yesterday. But he didn't come up to see the patients."

"Let him be," Vikram said. "The new shoes take time to fit."

The Barasat unit had a quarterly distribution day for the municipal health centers. Thirty-two medical kits, the driver, the loading supervisor, and a sign-off from the CEO.

The sign-off was required because one of the recipient health centers had flagged a discrepancy in the last quarter's batch—four kits sealed without the sterile packing inner layer. The government health inspector had written a note. The note had become a formal complaint. The formal complaint had landed on the CEO's desk the previous Thursday.

Rehman knew about the complaint. He had signed the acknowledgment slip himself.

On distribution day, Vikram got to the Barasat unit at nine because the driver had called him, not Rehman. The supervisor, a thin man named Karim, had been waiting since eight with the loading slip in his hand.

"Rehman sir said he would be here by eight-thirty," Karim said.

"He is delayed," Vikram said. He tried Rehman's number. It rang seven times without answer.

He called it again at nine-fifteen. The same seven rings.

At nine-thirty, the health inspector's representative arrived with a clipboard, ready to witness the handover and sign the clearance.

Vikram signed the loading slip himself. He checked each of the thirty-two kits against the manifest, opening two at random to confirm the inner packing. He initialed both. The inspector's representative looked at his signature, looked at the form, and said nothing.

By noon, the truck was loaded and had left for the distribution route.

Karim filled out the day's operational log. In the supervisor column, the line read: **Operations coordinated by Vikram Ahuja and Rehman sir.** This was because Karim had not been given any other instruction, and he was not the kind of man who left a line blank when he could fill it neatly.

Vikram saw the log entry. He didn't correct it.

Rehman called at four in the afternoon. His voice was normal, unhurried. "How did the distribution go, uncle?"

"Smoothly," Vikram said.

There was a pause. Not a long one, but a particular kind—the pause of a person checking how much has been noticed and deciding whether to offer an explanation.

Rehman didn't offer one. He said: "Good. I'll review Karim's log report tomorrow."

"Yes," Vikram said.

He set the phone down. Through the window of the Bagbazar house, a crow was walking along the compound wall, its head tilted sideways, checking the ground below for something.

Vikram watched it for a minute. Then he went back to the register table.

The phone near the register table rang at seven that evening. Vikram was alone in the room.

He walked out, his legs slightly stiff from the fever, and picked up the black receiver.

"Uncle," a voice said.

It was Rehman's voice. It was quiet now, the thick, drunk anger of the hotel terrace gone, replaced by a dry, hollow rattle.

"Rehman," Vikram said. "Where are you?"

"I am in Alipore," the boy said.

"Come to Bagbazar. The lawyer has sent the signed deeds."

A long silence followed down the line. The sound of city traffic, distant and light, came through the receiver.

"I cannot come, uncle," the boy said.

"Why?"

"I looked at the signature on the copy," Rehman said, his voice dropping. "The blue blur at the end. You didn't even read the clauses before signing."

"The clauses don't change the decision, Rehman."

"I am ashamed, uncle," the boy whispered. "I said those terrible things on the terrace. The candle, the sun. It was the whiskey."

"It is alright."

"It is not," Rehman said. "I cannot look at your face. I will handle the Barasat work from my Alipore office. Don't call me."

The line went dead, the dial tone returning in a dry hum. Vikram held the receiver for a minute, listening to the mechanical drone, before placing it back on the hook.

Rehman didn't call the next week, or the week after that. By the end of December, the manager of the Barasat unit called the Bagbazar house.

"Vikram babu," the manager said. "The salary release is pending. Rehman sir hasn't signed the bank authorization for the monthly wages."

"Is he not in Alipore?" Vikram asked.

"The apartment is locked, sir. The security guard said he left with two bags on Tuesday night. He took a local cab to the railway station."

Vikram took his small bag. He went to Alipore himself.

The apartment building was tall, the concrete walls painted cream, with large glass balconies reflecting the cold winter sun. The security guard, an old Gorkha named Thapa, was sitting on a red plastic chair near the gate.

He recognized Vikram from the newspaper photos immediately. "Rehman saab left," Thapa said.

"When?"

"Tuesday night, sir. He had two blue bags with him—the ones with the rusted zips."

"Did he leave an address?"

"No, sir. He just said he was going to Cuttack. He looked very sick, Vikram saab. His eyes were very dry, like he hadn't slept for weeks."

Vikram stood near the gate, looking at the parking slots.

A silver sedan, identical to the one Rehman had driven, was parked near the compound wall. It was covered in a thick layer of grey city dust, and someone had traced a name into the dirt of the rear glass window with a finger: **Ummmed**.

He looked at the dusty window. The Alipore house was locked, the silver sedan was empty, and Rehman was gone.

[End of Part 3]

PART 4

The press meet was held in the Bagbazar courtyard, under the shade of the largest neem tree. There were six plastic chairs arranged near the well, and one table covered with a faded green cloth.

Three reporters from the local Bengali dailies had arrived, along with a photographer who spent ten minutes cleaning his camera lens with his shirt tail before taking a single shot of the courtyard well.

Sarita sat near the table. She had returned from Delhi the night before, her wooden walking stick now carrying a small brass cap at the bottom that made a soft ringing sound against the stone floor.

Vikram stood near the green side gate.

A woman was sitting on the second plastic chair, holding a small reporter's notepad. She had grey hair at the temples, her glasses thick and tied to a black cord around her neck.

She was talking to a silver-haired man beside her, whose name was Aftab. He was her husband.

Vikram looked at her. The shape of the eyelids was the same, and the way she held the pen, the tip touching her lower lip as she read her notes, was identical.

It was Ira.

She looked up, her eyes moving across the courtyard. She saw him standing near the gate, his faded cotton shirt dusty from the sweeping work.

She stood up. She didn't run; she walked slowly, her sandals clicking against the stone tiles he had reset himself.

"Vikram," she said, her voice soft.

"Ira," Vikram said.

Aftab had followed her. He stood beside her, his face quiet and respectful, nodding to Vikram with the distance of a husband who had been told a version of an old story a long time ago.

"This is Aftab," she said. "We edit the Cuttack weekly newspaper now."

"I know," Vikram said.

"I saw the shelter," she said, looking around the clean courtyard and at Ananya who was writing in the green ledger. "It is good work, Vikram. The auto drivers at the crossing told me about the medicine deliveries. They call you Budha Baba."

"They have many names," Vikram said, his voice flat.

He looked at her eyes. "The cream-colored car," he said. "The one near the press building."

Ira looked down at her notepad, her hand adjusting her glasses. "I sold it," she said, her voice dropping. "Two weeks after you left it there. I used the money to clear my father's bank loan. It was enough to start the Cuttack weekly."

She looked at him again. "Thank you, Vikram. For leaving it."

"Rohan's office," Vikram said. "The letters you sent."

Ira's brow furrowed, her eyes showing genuine confusion. "Letters? I never sent any letters, Vikram. I haven't spoken to Rohan or his office since 1997."

Vikram felt a small, cold drop of sweat slide down his neck.

"The yellow envelope," he said. "From Cuttack. Rehman."

Ira looked at Aftab. Aftab looked at Vikram, his eyes moving from Vikram's face to the leather bag resting near the well.

"Rehman?" Ira asked. "Who is Rehman?"

"Your son," Vikram said, his voice rising slightly. "The boy who came to work here."

Ira stared at him. It was not a look of anger, but the deep, slow confusion of a journalist who has just realized a source is speaking in a language she doesn't understand.

"Vikram," she said, her voice very quiet. "I never had a son."

She paused, looking at her husband. "Aftab and I... we were married in ninety-eight. We didn't have children."

The telephone cabin on the corner of the Bagbazar lane smelled of old directories and dry tobacco. Vikram stood inside, his hand trembling as he dialled the phone number Rehman had left.

It was the number he had written in the ledger margins next to Rehman's name.

A click came from the exchange. Then the recorded voice, dry and mechanical, spoke:

The number you have dialled does not exist. Please check the directory.

He dialled again, his fingers cold. The same voice returned.

He hung up and walked back to the shelter courtyard. Ananya was sitting at her register table.

"Ananya," Vikram said. "Rehman's canvas bag. The blue one. Where is it?"

"He took it, uncle," she said. "When he went to Alipore."

"The photo," Vikram said. "The one he showed you on his phone. The one of his mother."

Ananya looked at him, her pen stopping over the green ledger. "He never showed me a photo, uncle."

"He did," Vikram said, his voice sharp. "In the kitchen. The day he arrived."

"No, uncle," she said, her eyes large and quiet. "He only had the wooden horse. He said he found it near the well. He never showed me a phone. He didn't have a phone."

Vikram walked into the study. The yellow envelope was sitting on the teak wood desk, near the brass lion paperweight.

He picked it up and pulled out the two ruled sheets of paper.

The paper was completely empty. No ink. No Cuttack postmark on the inside. No handwriting at all.

It was a property tax receipt from the municipal corporation, dated March 2015, sent to the **Ahuja Villa** address and forwarded by the local clerk.

The lawyer, Bannerjee, arrived at six in the evening. He sat on the step of the well, his leather briefcase kept on his knees. He didn't open it.

"The CEO transfer deed," Vikram said. "Where is it?"

"In my office, Vikram babu," the lawyer said.

"Whose name is on the recipient line?"

Bannerjee looked at the drumstick tree. "Your name," he said.

"My name?"

"Yes. The power of attorney was drafted in your name. You signed it, but you left the second signature blank. You told me Rehman would sign in Alipore."

"He did sign," Vikram said. "He called me. He said he saw the blue blur."

"Nobody signed, Vikram babu," the lawyer said, his voice dropping in the quiet courtyard. "The papers are still in my briefcase. I went to Alipore. The apartment was registered in the name of **Ummed Trust**, which is a subsidiary of Punarjeevan. The keys were with the security guard."

He looked at Vikram properly now. "The guard said you rented the flat three years ago. You paid the rent in advance from the Odisha bank account. Nobody ever lived there, Vikram babu."

"The silver sedan?"

"The sedan was bought by the trust," Bannerjee said. "You bought it yourself in 2018. It has been sitting in the Alipore garage since the day of purchase."

Vikram sat on the stone wall of the well. The red tea was boiling in the kitchen, the smell of ginger coming through the window. But the glass on the ledge was empty.

He looked at his hands, at the calluses, at the grey dirt under the nails.

The fourteen hundred crore was in Nandyal. The seventy-six hundred crore was in Alipore.

But the boy with the blue canvas bag and the rusted zip was not in Alipore. He had never been in Alipore.

[End of Part 4]

PART 5

The staff room of the Bagbazar shelter had seven plastic chairs and one long wooden bench where the junior volunteers sat.

Vikram stood near the glass window. The neem trees outside in the courtyard were losing their leaves, the dry yellow blades falling silently onto the grey stone floor.

"I am going," Vikram said, looking out at the yard.

Sarita looked up from the table. She was holding a glass of red tea, her hands trembling slightly against the warm glass. "Where?" she asked.

"Nowhere," Vikram said. "Just out."

"But the shelter, Vikram," one of the senior patients, an old tailor named Ghosh, said from his chair. "The Barasat license is still pending with the health department. The distributors won't talk to us if you're not here to sign."

"They will talk to Sarita," Vikram said, turning his head. "She has the register."

"We need you, Baba," Ananya said from the corner of the wooden bench.

She was eighteen now, her face mature. She was still holding the ledger with the green cloth cover, her fingers tracing the worn seam of the spine.

"The children at the school ask when you are coming to tell the crow story," she said. "They have been waiting in the yard since Tuesday."

"Tell them the crow flew away," Vikram said. He looked at her, his face quiet. "I want to be a free bird, Ananya."

"Even a bird has a nest, Vikram," Sarita said, her voice dropping.

"Only when it is tired," Vikram said.

He picked up his small leather bag. He had left his second shirt on the bench, carrying only the clothes he wore—a faded cotton kurta and the rubber slippers he had bought at the Shobhabazar market.

He walked out. He didn't use the main wooden door; he walked through the side corridor, passed the kitchen where the red tea was still simmering on the coal stove, and went out into the lane.

For three years, he lived on the streets of Bagbazar.

He slept on the concrete verandah of the Ramkrishna Mission, his head resting on his rolled-up canvas bag. The monks knew him as the quiet old man who swept the temple steps before the morning prayers began.

They offered him a plate of dal and rice in the noon. He ate what they gave, washed his steel plate at the tap, and sat near the river bank for the rest of the day, watching the boats.

The children near the local school started calling him Budha Baba. It wasn't because he was truly old, but because he had the time to sit on the concrete drain edge and listen to their stories about the street dogs and the broken kites.

He didn't carry a phone. If the shelter needed him, Ramu's nephew would walk down to the river bank and tell him. But they rarely called; they had learned to run the shelter's math themselves.

The call came on a rainy Tuesday morning in July 2018.

Vikram was sleeping on the verandah of the Mission, the wind from the Hooghly river spraying light drops of rain over his bare feet. Ramu's nephew came running through the mud, his shirt soaked, holding a plastic pouch containing Vikram's old Nokia phone.

"Baba," the boy said, out of breath. "Ananya called from the shelter. It is urgent."

Vikram took the phone out of the plastic. The screen was scratched, and the battery showed only one bar of green light. "Ananya?"

"Baba," her voice was fast, tight with the specific panic of the emergency ward. "It's Kavita. The girl from the Barasat branch. She got her medical report yesterday. She is standing at the bypass bridge. She wants to jump."

"I am coming," Vikram said.

He didn't take his bag. He left it on the Mission verandah, near the sweeper's broom.

He ran. His rubber slippers were thin, the soles sliding on the wet mud of the Bagbazar lanes. The bypass bridge was two kilometers away.

When he reached the bridge, Kavita was standing on the concrete ledge of the railing. Her hands were holding the cold iron pipe, and she was looking down at the railway tracks below.

The rain was heavier now, the water running fast along the concrete. A crowd of truck drivers had gathered at a distance, shouting, but nobody had gone close to her.

Vikram walked onto the bridge, his steps unhurried. He didn't shout. He didn't tell her that life was beautiful or that things would get better.

He simply stood beside her on the concrete ledge, his faded kurta soaked through by the rain, his feet cold in his slippers.

"The water down there is very dirty," Vikram said, looking at the tracks.

Kavita turned her head slowly, her face white, her eyes wet with the rain. "I have the bad blood, Baba," she whispered.

"I know," Vikram said. "Ananya had it too. She is still writing the ledger at the desk. Come. Ramu's nephew has the tea ready. It is cheap tea, but it is hot."

She looked at his hand. His hand was rough, the calluses yellow and hard from years of well rope, the nails grey with river sand.

"Come," he said again.

She looked at the tracks below, then she stepped down from the ledge. She didn't cry; she simply took his hand, her fingers cold and trembling against his calluses.

Vikram led her down the ramp to the police ambulance. A local MLA, who had arrived in a white Ambassador car with a red light on the top, stepped out of the vehicle.

He recognized Vikram from the old Kolkata press meets. "Ahuja saab," the MLA said, holding an umbrella over Vikram's head. "Get in. The car will drop you back to the hospital."

Vikram pushed the umbrella aside. "The car is too clean," Vikram said. "It will get wet."

He walked away. He crossed the bypass road, his slippers sliding on the mud.

The rain had stopped for a moment, the sun coming through the grey clouds and turning the wet road into a line of shining silver.

Behind him, a crowd had gathered near the bridge. A local strike was happening, and the workers were shouting slogans, throwing stones at the passing auto rickshaws.

A motorcycle came fast from the wrong side of the divider, its headlight off, its engine roaring over the shouts of the crowd.

Vikram didn't hear the horn. He was looking at the well tap of the shelter visible between the buildings, thinking of the hot red tea that would be waiting for him.

There was a sharp, dry sound of brakes, and then the impact.

He felt the road rising to meet his shoulder. He felt his rubber slipper flying off his foot into the air.

And then the darkness came, quiet and cold, like the shadow of the neem trees in the Bagbazar courtyard.

"Please... side... please... give a little side..."

The voice wasn't loud. Yet it cut through the noise of the casualty corridor.

An old man was lying on a stretcher, his white cotton shirt brown near the shoulder, one rubber slipper still remaining on his right foot.

The NGO girl was walking beside him, her left elbow bleeding, her sleeve torn. She bent down, removed the remaining slipper, and placed both carefully under the stretcher.

"It doesn't look nice," she said, her fingers dusty. "Wearing only one slipper."

[End of Chapter VI]

CHAPTER VII: COLORLESS TEARS

PART 1

The morning shift at the hospital began at six. The corridors were filled with the grey, cold light of an early dawn that hadn't yet cleared the smoke from the nearby railway yard.

Adarsh walked toward the casualty ward, his boots heavy on the stone floor. He hadn't slept for more than two hours during the night, his eyes carrying the dry, burning sensation of a long, anxious watch.

The crowd near the ICU door had not dispersed. They were still there, sitting on the cold floor with their backs against the green-painted brick wall, their hands empty.

The auto driver, the flower seller, and the school teacher were all silent. Nobody was holding flowers today, and nobody was whispering.

Ananya sat on the same wooden chair near the corner. The bamboo walking stick with the tiny strip of red cloth was leaning against her shoulder.

She wasn't looking at the ICU doors anymore. She was looking down at the rubber slippers kept carefully under the empty stretcher frame near the wall—both slippers, clean and placed side by side.

After a moment, she picked the walking stick up from her shoulder and held it properly in her hand, the way you hold something you have decided not to put down again.

Adarsh slowed his pace as he reached the swing doors.

The ICU door was open. Inside, the monitor beside table nine was silent, the green screen completely blank, and the black power cord was unplugged and wound neatly around the metal stand.

The white sheet on the bed was pulled all the way to the top, showing only the outline of a thin shoulder and the long, still frame of the legs underneath.

The senior nurse was standing near the steel medicine cabinet, sorting the unused ampoules of adrenaline back into the plastic partition tray. She saw Adarsh enter, set the tray down on the shelf, and turned to face him.

"At four-fifteen, sir," she said, her voice dropping. "The blood pressure dropped suddenly. We gave the dopamine infusion, but the heart was too tired to respond."

Adarsh stood near the side of the bed. He didn't pull the sheet back to look at the face.

As a doctor, he had pulled back a hundred sheets during his career. He had checked the pupils for light response, felt the cold neck for the carotid pulse, and signed the time of death on the margins of the case files.

But he didn't touch this sheet. He simply looked at the white outline under the cloth.

The distance between the anatomy dissection table in 1995 and this silent ICU bed in 2018 was twenty-three years. He had spent the entire night in his quarters thinking of the questions he would ask when Vikram finally woke up.

Why didn't you write to me?

Where did the company go?

Who was Rehman?

Now, the sheet was closed. The questions had stayed in his own head, and there was no other room in the world where the answers would ever be spoken.

"A lady is waiting for you in the visitor's room," the nurse said, closing the medicine drawer with a soft click. "Dr. Sen. The psychiatrist from the Kolkata medical college. She has the patient's records from 2016."

Adarsh looked at the white sheet one last time. Then he turned, walked out of the ICU, passed the crowd sitting silently against the wall, and went toward the visitor's wing.

Near the corner of the corridor, the old tea seller was starting his coal stove. The blue flame groaned as it caught the kerosene, smelling of oil and the dry, cold air of the morning.

[End of Part 1]

PART 2

Dr. Sen was sitting at the corner wooden table of the hospital visitor's room. She was fifty, perhaps fifty-two years old, wearing a simple silk saree that had the dull grey color of river silt.

She had three folders placed neatly on the table, their brown cardboard covers held together by thin, red cotton strings.

"I expected you earlier, Dr. Tripathy," she said, looking up as he walked in.

Adarsh sat in the wooden chair across from her, resting his hands on the table. "The morning shift took some time to transition," he said.

"Sarita brought him to my clinic in Shobhabazar in 2016," she said, opening the first folder. "He had been found sitting in the Alipore garage, staring at the empty silver sedan for eight hours without moving."

Adarsh looked at the papers inside the folder. The notes were written in a quick, clinical hand, with dates and observations covering the margins.

"He told me about Rehman," she said. "He described the canvas bag, the rusted zip, the way the boy painted the kitchen, even his Odia accent. He said the boy had Ira's eyes."

"Ira," Adarsh said, his voice quiet.

"He carried her memory like a stone in his shoe," she said. "Every step hurt, but he had stopped trying to shake it out."

She turned a page, the paper making a dry, sharp rustle in the quiet room.

"The yellow envelope was real," she said. "But it was only a municipal tax receipt. Vikram needed a reason to let the boy in. So his split mind read Ira's name on the cheap yellow paper."

"Why did he need the projection?" Adarsh asked.

"Because he was tired of the split," she said, looking out through the window at the hospital parking lot. "One half of him had built the fourteen hundred crore. The other half had left the anatomy lab in ninety-six, leaving a textbook half-underlined. He wanted the well, but the tycoon in him couldn't stop building."

She tapped the brown folder with her finger.

"Rehman was the alternate choice. The boy who could buy the silver sedan, fly to Geneva, and run the business, while Vikram slept on the wooden bench in Bagbazar. Rehman was the one who could shout at him on the terrace."

"The terrace," Adarsh said. "The candle and the sun."

"It was Vikram's own voice," she said, looking at him. "He had given the entire empire to Rohan. He had walked away. But even in Bagbazar, the local MLA still called him **Ahuja saab**. He couldn't escape the name. He was guilty that his legacy followed him."

She closed the folder.

"The real Ira Sen appearing at the press meet broke the split. The moment she said she never had a son, the alternate choice had to end. Rehman had to disappear."

"Did Vikram know?" Adarsh asked.

"He knew," she said. "He told me he signed the CEO transfer with a blue blur because the space for the second name was blank. He said: **I wanted to give the pen to Rehman. But Rehman had no hand to take it.**"

Then she set the files back down on the table, as if she had remembered something.

"He told me one other thing," she said. "He told it to me not as a fact, but as a question he couldn't resolve."

She looked at the window. "During the year his father's condition first became serious—1996—there was a formal dinner at the house. Some supplier's anniversary, food on the good plates, people Vikram didn't know. Halfway through the meal, someone handed Binay a phone. He took the call. He came back to the table very quietly and said nothing to anyone. But his face had gone completely still."

"What had happened?" Adarsh asked.

"His oldest brother had died that evening. The one in Cuttack."

"I didn't know Binay had a brother."

"Most people didn't. They were estranged." She turned her eyes from the window. "But here is the thing Vikram couldn't reconcile. His father sat back down at the dinner table, picked up the gulab jamun they had just been served, and put it in his mouth. Ate it completely. Then he wiped his hands on the cloth napkin and continued the dinner."

Adarsh said nothing.

"Vikram asked me: **Is it possible to swallow sweetness like poison? Or was he swallowing the news in small pieces, the way the stomach accepts what the mind cannot?** He said he watched his father's throat move as he swallowed the jamun, and he never forgot the sound of it." She paused. "I didn't have a clinical answer for that."

I still don't."

She opened the second folder briefly, turned a page. "He also spoke at length about Ira. About why he had wanted her specifically, not merely someone like her."

"He spoke about it directly?" Adarsh asked.

"With considerable clarity, actually." She turned the page back. "He said—and I am quoting from my notes—I did not chase her because she was beautiful, though she was. I chased her because I wanted to know what everything looked like from behind her eyes. She had a way of seeing the same event I had seen and finding in it something I had entirely missed. I wanted that perspective. I thought if I was close enough to her, some of it would transfer. It never does. It never has, with anyone. But the illusion that it might—that is the thing we are really chasing when we chase someone. Not them. The version of the world that lives inside them."

She closed the folder.

"You agree?" Adarsh asked.

"I find it more accurate than most things men say about why they loved someone," she said, without inflection.

She was quiet for a moment, looking at the brown cardboard covers.

"The last thing he said to me about the business years," she continued, "was this. He said: 'When I was building the company, I enjoyed it the way you enjoy arriving. The destination was always ahead. When I was building the shelter, I enjoyed it the way you enjoy walking. Every day was the thing, not the end of the thing.' He said: 'I have never understood people who chase money. They are always looking at the target. They cannot see the road. People who chase feeling are looking at the road. The target doesn't matter to them, which is why they usually don't find it either.' He smiled when he said that. It was a slow smile, the kind that seemed to have travelled a long way before it reached his face.

She tied the red string around the cardboard folder, the knot tight, neat, and final.

"His case was simple, Dr. Tripathy. Some minds break because they are weak. His broke because it was too honest to keep the palace and the well at the same time."

She looked at him before picking up the files. "His smiles were transparent," she said. "But his tears... they had no color."

Adarsh sat in the wooden chair, silent. The visitor's room was completely quiet now.

The lawyer's deeds were in Dalhousie Square, the Alipore house was locked, and the factory compound gates in Nandyal were opening and closing. Somewhere, near the edge of a coffee estate he had never returned to, a fire had probably gone cold. He had never thanked the man who lit it. But the case file on the table was the only thing that had his friend's name written on the cover.

"Thank you, doctor," Adarsh said.

She picked up the folders and left. Her leather sandals made a quiet, clicking sound against the corridor floor, fading away until only the scratching sound of the old ceiling fan remained in the room.

[End of Part 2]

PART 3

Rohan took the body back to Odisha. The head office had sent a private ambulance, the white Ambassador kind, the driver wearing the company uniform with the grey epaulettes on the shoulders.

Rohan did not speak to Adarsh. He stood near the casualty counter, signed the release forms, his signature neat, clear, and steady—the signature he had learned to write after Vikram left the board.

His hand did not tremble today. The red Nandyal dust had gone from his shoes, replaced by polished black leather that reflected the bright hospital corridor lights.

At the ambulance door, he paused. His hand was on the handle. He did not look back. But he stood there for three seconds longer than necessary, long enough for the driver to glance at him in the rear-view mirror and then look away again.

Then he got in and closed the door.

Ananya and Sarita left in the evening. They had the Howrah train tickets, ready to return to Bagbazar.

"Come to Bagbazar, Dr. Tripathy," Sarita said, pausing at the hospital gate. "The neem trees are green now."

"I will come," Adarsh said.

He watched the auto rickshaw carry them away toward the station, its yellow and green frame disappearing into the traffic. Ananya was sitting in the back, the three-legged wooden horse kept on her lap, her hand holding the green ledger tight.

She did not look back.

Adarsh returned to his small hospital quarters room at eight. The room was small, smelling of old paper, damp brick, and the cup of tea he had left unfinished on the side table.

He went to the wooden cupboard near the corner. He opened the lowest shelf, reaching behind the old medical journals and the dusty folders of forgotten cases.

The pathology textbook was still there. He pulled it out.

The cover was grey with the dust of twenty-two years, the corners frayed, the cardboard backing showing through the peeling blue paper.

*He opened the book. He turned to Chapter three: **Hepatic cirrhosis.***

The line was still there, the blue ink of Vicky's pen dry and faded, ending mid-sentence near the paper margin.

Decompensated liver function is marked by portal hypertension...

He closed the book slowly. He kept it on the desk near his stethoscope.

Vikram had left the room. He had left the white coat, the fourteen hundred crore, and the seventy-six hundred crore.

Most people who wrote his obituary in the business weekly would write about the empire he had surrendered. They would call him a loser.

They would say he was a tycoon who couldn't keep his grip on the wheel, a success that had gone soft at the end.

Adarsh walked to the window. The hospital lights below were yellow, shining on the wet asphalt of the M.G. Road.

The auto rickshaws honked. The vendors shouted. The city went on.

*But as he looked at his own white apron hanging on the wooden peg on the wall, the blue thread stitching on the pocket—**Adarsh Tripathy**—still neat and clear after thirty years of shifts, he wondered.*

Who is the loser?

Is it he? Or is it we, who sit in our comfortable chairs, making comfortable decisions, holding onto our names until the name is the only thing left of us?

He had no answer. The book on the table was closed, and the window was dark.

And the story of Vikram Ahuja had ended exactly where it began—on a wooden bench, under the shadow of a neem tree, with a glass of red tea that had gone cold in the wind.

[End of Novel]